When Women Run Against Men: Evidence from Political Platforms

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Abstract

Do female and male candidates campaign differently, and why? Using individual political platforms from French legislative elections between 1981 and 2024, I combine a transformer machine learning model with a regression discontinuity design that exploits the two-round structure of French elections to identify the causal impact of candidate gender on campaign content. Female and male candidates who barely qualify discuss the same issues in the first-round, but women write 6 percentage points less of their platform in a communal register. Between the two rounds, the gender gap in male-stereotyped topics rises by 4.7 percentage points, driven by male candidates, who withdraw from these topics and reallocate space to framing the national contest. This effect appears only when male politicians compete against another man, as they try to differentiate themselves from their opponents. Women increase their use of communal language, closing the gender gap, but do not adapt their behavior to their opponent's gender.

Keywords: Elections, gender, natural language processing

JEL classification: D72, J16, P0

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1 Introduction

The share of women in politics has increased remarkably in almost every country over the past few decades. In 1988, women accounted for only 8.9% of candidates in US primaries; by 2024, they accounted for 26.2% (peaking at 29.1% in 2020).[1] In France, the share increased from 11.5% to 41.1% in the same period. The rising number of women in politics might significantly affect the policies discussed if women and men have different preferences. How do women differ from men during political campaigns, and why do such differences arise? Understanding these differences matters because candidate communication shapes the information voters receive and can influence which policy areas gain political attention.

To win an election, candidates must master campaign communication and carefully decide which policy issues to advertise and how to communicate them. How candidates choose to communicate may differ between men and women. At the same time, leadership has been predominantly a male prerogative in politics. According to role congruity theory, gender roles are shared expectations and beliefs about women's and men's attributes and behavior that "follow from observations of people in sex-typical social roles" - especially political leadership (Eagly & Karau, 2002; Rudman & Glick, 2001). Voters associate men with competence in security, crime, and defense, and women with competence in health, education, and compassion (Huddy & Terkildsen, 1993). In addition, social psychology organizes two complementary ways human beings exist and interact with others: agency and communion (Abele & Wojciszke, 2007; Bakan, 1966). These are also dimensions on which gender stereotypes are defined: men are expected to be assertive and decisive, women to be warm and relationship-oriented (Diekman & Eagly, 2000; Haines, Deaux, & Lofaro, 2016). Stereotypes operate not only through how others evaluate a person but also through beliefs about one's own ability: Coffman (2014) finds that individuals are less willing to contribute their ideas in domains perceived as incongruent with their gender, even conditional on actual ability, and Bordalo, Coffman, Gennaioli, and Shleifer (2019) show that these beliefs are shaped by the stereotype-relevant features of the comparison at hand. If candidates hold such beliefs, or expect voters to hold them, then broadening a campaign is not symmetric: a man who moves onto security issues or campaigns with an agentic tone and a woman who moves onto health and uses a communal language are not making the same strategic bet, even when the electoral logic pushing them to move is identical.

Studying how female and male candidates differ in their campaigns is method-

[1] Source: Center for American Women and Politics.

ologically challenging. Female candidacy is endogenous to local electoral conditions, and systematic data on campaign discourse are scarce. In most contexts, records of candidates' campaign platforms are incomplete or limited to those who ultimately win office, so the literature focuses primarily on behavior once elected.

I overcome these challenges by focusing on French legislative elections, which use a two-round system in which the same electorate votes twice. With an average of nine candidates in the first-round and two in the second, candidates face incentives to adjust their messages between rounds, creating a natural setting to observe strategic signaling in response to voter evaluations. To address endogeneity, I exploit quasi-experimental variation in the candidate's gender. Using a regression discontinuity design, I examine whether female (male) candidates shift their platform topics between the first and second-rounds. The research design compares a female politician who barely passes to the second-round instead of a male in that district with a male politician who barely qualifies instead of a female. To support the identification strategy, I show that a large set of voters' and districts' characteristics, as well as the candidate's individual characteristics (except gender), are balanced at the threshold.

The empirical analysis draws on a comprehensive dataset of candidates' official campaign platforms, which the French state distributes to all registered voters. Using a transformer-based machine learning model built specifically to understand and process the French language (CamemBERT), I quantify topic prevalence. I find that in the first-round, female and male candidates do not differ significantly in the content of their campaigns. Between the first and second-round, the gap on male-stereotyped topics (justice, criminality and immigration) increases by 4.7 percentage points. Who moves? Decomposing the estimate into the average change on each side of the threshold, I conclude that men reduce the prevalence of the respective stereotype topic between rounds. The results are only significant when men compete against another man, which I interpret as platform differentiation. When compared to another man, male-stereotyped topics do not allow for distinguishing between the two candidates, as both are presumed competent in them and prefer to cover other topics.

I also explore gender differences in rhetorical style. Drawing on psychological theory (Bem, 1974) and using a large language model (LLM), I construct two independent measures of agency and communion. Role congruity theory predicts that women's use of agentic language will be evaluated less favorably than men's equivalent behavior because it is perceived as less desirable in women (Eagly & Karau, 2002). On the other hand, if women display communion, they conform to the female gender role but fail to conform to the leader role. I find that in the first-

round women use less agentic language (although only significant at 10 percent) and use less communal language by 6.0 percentage points (significant at 1 percent). Between the first and second-round, women increase the use of communal language and close the gender gap.

These adjustments respond to competitive pressure. They concentrate among candidates who enter the runoff behind their opponent: each additional point of first-round disadvantage widens the gender gap in health and male-stereotyped topics, while front-runners adjust their male and female platforms similarly. Similarly, female candidates use communal language only when they enter the runoff behind their opponent.

Are candidates' strategic behavior electorally compensated? Following Acharya, Blackwell, and Sen (2016), I estimate average controlled direct effects by sequential g-estimation to ask whether the adjustment affects second-round vote shares. It does not. No detectable gender gap emerges in runoff performance, and fixing the adjustment at the same value for all candidates leaves that gap unchanged; the estimated return to adjustment is small and statistically indistinguishable from zero for both men and women. That candidates adjust along gendered lines even though the adjustment has no detectable electoral return is more consistent with shared expectations about how men and women are supposed to campaign than with a vote-maximizing response to voter preferences.

Contribution to the literature The paper contributes to three main strands of the literature. First, it contributes to the literature on gender and political representation. Several studies have shown that women prefer to work on policies that benefit female voters (Chattopadhyay and Duflo (2004)) or in domains such as health and child care, which are usually stereotyped as female (Bhalotra and Clots-Figueras (2014), Funk and Gathmann (2015), Lippmann (2021), Baskaran and Hessami (2025)). In contrast, other studies find no significant differences (Ferreira and Gyourko (2014), Bagues and Campa (2021), Casarico, Lattanzio, and Profeta (2022)). This literature focuses on elected politicians because data are considerably easier to obtain. To my knowledge, my paper provides the first causal description of gender differences during political campaigns. The results show that a race's gender composition affects the issues discussed, a margin of political representation that operates before any woman is elected.

Second, it contributes to the literature on gender stereotypes and behavior. Experimental work in economics shows that stereotypes operate through beliefs about one's own ability in gender-incongruent domains (Coffman, 2014) and that such beliefs respond to the composition of the relevant comparison (Bordalo et al., 2019), while work on competitive environments shows that behavior depends

on the gender composition of the contest (Gneezy, Niederle, & Rustichini, 2003; Iriberri & Rey-Biel, 2017; Niederle & Vesterlund, 2007). This pattern has been confirmed in elections (Kanthak and Woon (2015), Barber, Butler, Preece, et al. (2016)). These works have largely focused on entry decisions and laboratory settings. This paper adds a unique setting: the same individual is observed twice, one week apart, as the audience shifts from a crowded first-round to a two-candidate runoff, and the candidate's identity is determined by a discontinuity rather than selection. Among men, the opponent's gender matters because it determines what distinguishes the two candidates rather than because it activates a belief about the self, so the contest's gender composition shapes behavior through differentiation rather than through self-stereotyping.

Third, it contributes to the literature on strategic platform choice. The Median Voter Theorem (Downs (1957)) assumes the parties' unique objective is winning elections. Consequently, if two parties have the same information about voters' preferences, they will converge on the median voter's viewpoint, ignoring politicians' identities. However, candidates only converge to a certain extent. Citizen-candidate models show that politicians care about policy implementation, not just victory (Alesina (1988), Osborne and Slivinski (1996), Besley and Coate (1997)). Le Pennec (2023) shows that French candidates adjust the content of their communication between rounds as the electorate they address widens, and Di Tella, Kotti, Le Pennec, and Pons (2025) document strategic platform adjustment in French and U.S. elections. I show that these adjustments are gendered and that the gender composition of the runoff changes the campaign's overall issue content.

2 Institutional context

2.1 French parliamentary elections

The paper focuses on parliamentary elections that elect all members of the National Assembly, the lower house of Parliament.

These elections are held under direct universal suffrage with a two-round plurality voting rule. Candidates can win in the first-round if they receive more than 50 percent of the votes and at least 25 percent of the registered voters. However, in 86.62% of elections, no candidate is elected in the first round, leading to a second-round held one week later. The second-round is decided by simple plurality: the candidate with the largest vote share wins.

Candidates who obtain at least 12.5 percent of the eligible voters' vote share qualify for the second round. However, if only one candidate (or none) meets the

threshold, the two candidates with the largest vote share can proceed to the second round. This last situation accounts for 26.93% of all elections.

Selection of political candidates It is possible to run for one of the 577 French constituencies without being affiliated to a party as long as the aspiring MP meets all the necessary conditions to enter the race, in particular being at least 18 years old, having the right to vote, and not being ineligible (because of a court decision or a function incompatible with the mandate of an MP, such as being mayor). However, most candidates run under a party label, making them much more visible to voters.

Under the 2000 gender parity law, parties must present an equal fraction of male and female candidates across the electoral districts. If the difference between female and male candidates exceeds 4% (48% females and 52% males, or the reverse), non-compliance with the gender parity rules results in a financial penalty. The financial penalty is calculated as follows: "public funding provided to political parties based on the number of votes they receive in the first-round of elections is reduced by a percentage equivalent to one-half of the difference between the total number of candidates of each sex, out of the total number of candidates" (Le Barbanchon and Sauvagnat (2022)). In France, voters vote for two candidates: the leading candidate, who, if elected, becomes an MP, and the substitute. The last one replaces the top candidate only if he leaves office; potential reasons include being nominated to a function incompatible with the mandate of an MP (e.g., minister, secretary of state, or elected as a mayor), or death/health issues. In most cases, the substitute never becomes an MP during the legislative term and only has a symbolic role. After the law's approval, in the 2002 legislative elections, women accounted for 38.8% of the leading candidates, compared to 23% in the 1997 legislative elections.

2.2 Political platforms

During the legislative campaign, individual candidates can emit one political platform (*trans.* profession de foi) before each election round.[2] The appendix provides one example in Figure B.1. What is the traditional content of a political platform? A manifesto allows a candidate to present the program and ideas they plan to commit to if elected. Since they represent an electoral district, candidates might run a campaign by focusing on national policies and/or addressing local issues. They can also run a more partisan program, personalize their campaign, focus on pre-

[2]Throughout the paper, I use the words "political platform" and "manifesto" interchangeably; in this paper, they are synonymous.

ferred policy topics, or, as expected, appeal to voters and criticize the opposition.

Candidates must print these platforms, and the state can reimburse the costs if they win at least 5% of the votes in one of the rounds (Electoral law, articles R39 and L216). An official local propaganda committee is responsible for mailing the manifestos to voters at least four days before the first round and three days before the second round (if it happens).[3]

According to the Ipsos - CEVIPOF 2022 Presidential electoral survey, the primary sources of candidates' information are: 38% of the electors follow television, 15% the internet (many candidates share their platforms online), 13% newspapers, 12% the manifestos received in the mailbox, 6% use other sources around them, and 16% do not inform. Relatively to the 1988, 1993, and 1997 manifestos, the internet was not yet widely available and used. Furthermore, per election, there are 577 constituencies and an average of 5800 candidates, making it impossible for television to cover them all. Consequently, platforms are likely more important in legislative than presidential elections.

3 Data

3.1 Electoral data

Each dataset records the number of registered voters, abstentions, cast votes, valid and invalid votes, and each candidate's votes in each electoral district. From 1981 to 2017, I use data from Granzier, Pons, and Tricaud (2023). The dataset also includes information on the candidate's first and last name, gender, political affiliation, incumbency status, and whether the candidate ran in the past. For 2022 and 2024, I use data from the Ministry of Interior.

The Ministry of Interior has also provided information on candidates' dates of birth and occupations since 2012. Several candidates provide personal information in their manifestos, including their occupation and age. Before 2012, I prompted ChatGPT to read each political program and provide the main candidate's occupation and age. I then construct five dummy variables: out of the labor force (e.g., unemployed, retired, student), high-skilled worker (e.g., managers, engineers, lawyers), middle-skilled (e.g., agents, social assistants, merchants), low-skilled (e.g., craftsmen, factory workers, farmers), and a missing category.

I use the official party labels provided by the Ministry of the Interior to classify candidates (including independent ones), and following Jolly et al. (2022), I

[3]These platforms are only mailed if they obey these rules: they must have a maximum size of 210x297 millimeters, weigh between 60 and 80 grams per square meter (Electoral law, article R29) (Le Pennec (2023)).

classify them into six partisan families: far-left, left, liberal, right, far-right, and other. The last category includes politicians who do not fit into any of these traditional ideological categories or who do not identify with any ideology. In the rest of the paper, I refer to political orientation as the broader categories "left" (far-left and left) and "right" (liberal, right and far-right), unless specified otherwise. Essentially, I classify "left" parties as the ones that score less than 5 in the left-right dimension of Jolly et al. (2022) and "right" as the ones that score more than 6.[4] Party classification is available in Appendix Section A.

Campaign contributions Data on campaign expenditures and contributions from 1993 to 2017 come from Bekkouche, Cagé, and Dewitte (2022). For 2022 and 2024, I use data from the National Commission on Campaign Accounts and Political Financing (CNCCFP). In French parliamentary elections, candidates who receive at least 1% of the votes in the first-round must submit their campaign accounts to the French CNCCFP. This commission was created in 1990, so data before that date is unavailable. For each year, electoral district, and candidate, I observe, for the whole campaign, the total amount spent by the candidate, the total amount of contributions he received, and the amount of each type of contribution: contributions received from the candidate's political party, donations, and personal funds.

3.2 Political platforms

The Archelec project digitized candidate manifestos for the 1981, 1988 and 1993 elections (Gaultier-Voituriez (2016)).[5][6] Platforms for the 1997 elections were digitized from the National Archives. For the 2002, 2007 and 2012 elections, I use data from Di Tella et al. (2025).[7] The data for 2012 are complemented with data from the French National Assembly website, which provides the political platforms of all elected politicians.[8]

[4] According to Jolly et al. (2022), all liberal parties in the sample have a left-right score between 6 and 7, in a spectrum between 0 and 10.

[5] They are available at `https://archive.org/details/archiveselectoralesducevipof/`

[6] The Archelec project (Gaultier-Voituriez (2016)) includes data since 1958; however, I only start in 1981, since before this period any observation would be included in the regression discontinuity design; there are no women who barely passed to the second round.

[7] Di Tella et al. (2025) have comprehensively collected data for the 2021 local elections. However, each *canton* elects two councilors: a male and a female candidate who campaign on a common platform; therefore, it is not possible to study gender differences in local political campaigns, and the article focuses solely on parliamentary campaigns.

[8] They are available at: `https://www.assemblee-nationale.fr/dyn/decouvrir-l-assemblee/histoire/barodet2/recueil-des-professions-de-foi-de-la-14eme-legislature`.

For 2017, they come from several sources: during the campaign, the Ministry of Interior shares the manifestos submitted by the candidates on their website[9], and they were web-scraped by a non-profit organization called RegardsCitoyens[10]. In addition, I manually digitized missing manifestos at CEVIPOF (Sciences Po), the National Assembly website also shares the manifestos of all elected MPs[11], some missing manifestos were also found on several local news or candidate websites. For 2022 and 2024, platforms come from the Ministry of Interior website and several local news and candidate websites.

The dataset comprises 33686 political platforms, 26630 for the first-round, and 7056 for the second-round. Optical character recognition (Mistral OCR) transformed these platforms from images to text.

3.3 Measurement

3.3.1 Topics

To measure the thematic content of political text, I classify each sentence in the corpus into one or two of eleven topics using a supervised multi-label classifier based on CamemBERT (Antoun et al. (2024)), a transformer language model pretrained on French text. The classification is performed at the paragraph level, and the corpus comprises approximately 597 thousand sentences. The classification proceeds in three stages: (i) construction of an annotated training set using a large language model (LLM), (ii) fine-tuning of CamemBERT on this training set, and (iii) inference on the full corpus.

I adopt a multi-label framework: each sentence may be assigned to more than one topic simultaneously. This choice reflects the nature of political discourse, where a single sentence often spans several policy domains—for example, a statement about the green economy belongs to both the economic and environmental domains.

I define eleven mutually intelligible categories: (1) Economy, (2) Employment and social security, (3) Environment, (4) Health, (5) Education, (6) Justice and criminality, (7) Immigration, (8) Foreign policy, (9) Local politics, (10) National politics, and (11) Other, a residual category reserved for procedural language, fragments, and sentences without identifiable content.

[9]They are available at: `https://programme-candidats.interieur.gouv.fr/`

[10]They are available at: `https://github.com/regardscitoyens/professions-foi-candidats/tree/master/documents/LG17`

[11]They are available at: `https://www.assemblee-nationale.fr/dyn/decouvrir-l-assemblee/histoire/barodet2/recueil-des-professions-de-foi-de-la-15eme-legislature`

Supervised classification requires annotated training data. I annotated about 50,000 sentences sampled from both manifesto corpora using GPT-5.4-mini and a structured French-language prompt. In Appendix Table B2, I share the prompt provided, translated into English.

I apply the fine-tuned classifier to all 597 thousand paragraphs. For each sentence, the model outputs a probability for each of the nine topics; assign a topic when its probability exceeds 0.6, and if no topic clears the threshold, assign the sentence 'other'. For each paragraph, I retain the full set of assigned topics, the highest-probability (top) topic, the second-ranked topic, and the associated probabilities.

To reduce measurement error and facilitate interpretation, I aggregate all topics into three main categories: (1) female-stereotyped topics: health and education; (2) male-stereotyped topics: justice and immigration; (3) other: the remaining topics. The empirical analysis aggregates paragraph-level classifications to the candidate level and computes each topic's share in the manifesto/debates.

Validation Transformers are a powerful approach for topic classification because they can capture the context and semantic meaning of words within a sentence, rather than relying primarily on word frequencies or predefined dictionaries. When fine-tuned for topic classification, CamemBERT can therefore identify nuanced thematic content in French political texts and distinguish between closely related topics. Since the topic measure is central to every result that follows, I assess its quality along three dimensions: internal classification performance, agreement with human judgment, and agreement with an independent automated classifier.

Table B3 reports per-class precision, recall, and F1-scores across the eleven topic categories. Performance is uniformly high and, importantly, does not deteriorate for the categories that carry the analysis: health (F1 $= 0.88$), education (0.86), justice and criminality (0.87), and immigration (0.82). The lowest scores appear for immigration and the residual category, which is expected given their smaller training support and, in the case of the residual category, its definition as a catch-all rather than a substantive topic.

The analysis was also validated against an independent human annotator. A random sample of 1000 paragraphs was provided to the human annotator, and the classification was done into female-stereotyped topics (health and education), male-stereotyped topics (justice & criminality and immigration), and other. Table B4 reports the results. The classifier reaches an F1-score of 0.746 for female-stereotyped content, 0.764 for male-stereotyped content, and 0.957 for the residual category. Recall exceeds precision for female-stereotyped paragraphs (0.824 ver-

sus 0.682), and the pattern reverses for male-stereotyped paragraphs (0.748 versus 0.782), indicating mild over-assignment of the former and mild under-assignment of the latter relative to human judgment.

In addition, the analysis was also validated against a large language model (ChatGPT 5.4 version) and, finally, between the LLM and the human annotator. Tables B5 and B6 report the comparisons, respectively. The language model agrees with the human annotator at almost the same rate as the classifier: F1-scores of 0.763 and 0.754 for the two stereotyped categories, versus 0.746 and 0.764 for the classifier.

3.3.2 Agentic vs communal language

I build on the distinction between agency and communion, the two fundamental dimensions of social judgment (Abele & Wojciszke, 2007). Agentic language presents the candidate as acting with determination, strength, and control: fighting for an outcome, deciding, leading, and obtaining results. Communal language presents the candidate as oriented toward others: listening, being close to and available for constituents, attending to people's concerns, and acting in cooperation with them. Role congruity theory (Eagly & Karau, 2002) predicts that these registers carry different costs and benefits for women and men seeking office, since the political role is stereotypically agentic while women are expected to be communal.

A central feature of the measure is that it captures the register in which candidates present themselves, not the topics they address. I classify each segment using a large language model (ChatGPT 5.4-mini). I use two separate binary prompts, one for each register, so that a segment can be agentic, communal, both, or neither. Treating the two dimensions independently follows the psychological literature, which treats agency and communal as distinct dimensions rather than opposite poles of a single scale. In Appendix Tables B7 and B8, I share the prompt provided for agentic and communal language, respectively.

I prefer this approach to dictionary methods for two reasons. First, dictionaries cannot identify who performs an action (e.g., "we will ask the government to remain attentive to the elderly"; the communal word refers to the government, not the candidate). Second, building a dictionary that captures all agentic and communal words is difficult, and some may be conflated with policy vocabulary (e.g., solidarity, support, energy).

The agentic and communal measures are the share of paragraphs classified as agentic and communal, respectively, taking values between 0 and 1.

4 Empirical strategy

Do female candidates campaign differently from male candidates? Answering this question is empirically challenging because female presence in a race is endogenous. Previous research has shown that various factors such as party discrimination (Esteve-Volart and Bagues (2012), Lippmann (2021)), voter bias (Le Barbanchon and Sauvagnat (2022)), or previous female success might affect women's willingness to run (Beaman, Chattopadhyay, Duflo, Pande, and Topalova (2009), Bhavnani (2009), Baskaran and Hessami (2018)). A quasi-experiment is necessary to understand how gender affects politicians' strategic behavior in a competitive electoral environment.

As noted in Section 2.1, in races where only one or no candidate received 12.5% of the votes, only the two most-voted candidates are eligible for the second-round. I focus on races in which the second-place candidate's vote share was below 12.5%. To estimate the causal impact of gender on campaign strategies, I use a sharp regression discontinuity design (RDD) and compare female candidates who narrowly passed to the second-round (while a male was not barely eligible in that electoral district) with male candidates who narrowly passed to the second-round (while a female was almost eligible). I estimate the following equation:

$$Y_i = \beta_0 + \beta_1 T_i + \beta_2 R_i + \beta_3 R_i T_i + \mu_i \tag{1}$$

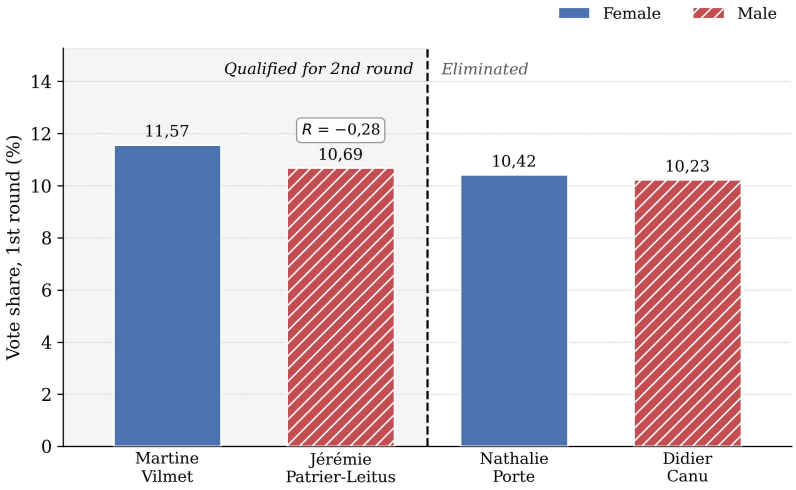
The outcome variable Y_i is the difference in the share of a policy topic between the second and the first-round. The treatment variable T is a dummy equal to one if the candidate is a woman and 0 if the candidate is a man in the second-round. The running variable R is the difference between the share of votes obtained by the most-voted female and male candidate, ignoring the opponent in the second-round. The unit of observation is the candidate.

Following Calonico, Cattaneo, Farrell, and Titiunik (2019), I nonparametrically estimate the coefficient of interest using local linear regressions. I use the mean squared error optimal bandwidths (MSERD) selection procedure proposed by Calonico, Cattaneo, and Titiunik (2014). This procedure is data-driven, implying that bandwidth size varies with the outcome under consideration.

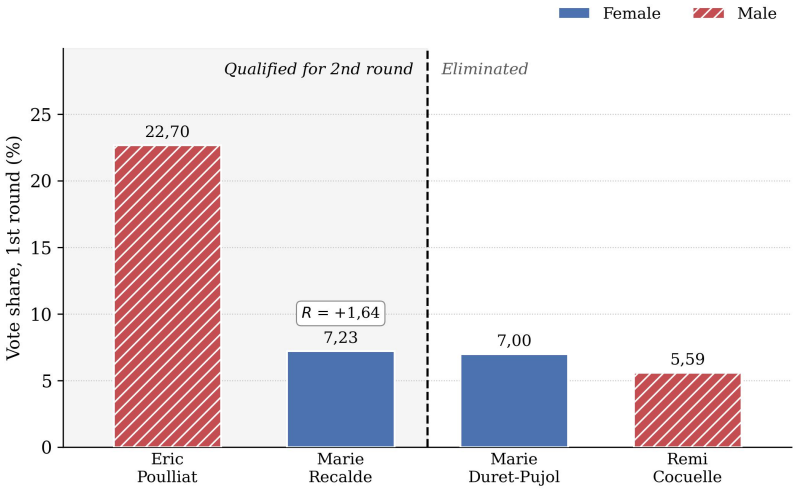
Sample In Table C10, I provide summary statistics comparing all candidates with those included in the sample and within a cutoff of 3 percentage points. Table C11 shows the number of observations included in the sampling frame each year. Most of the variation available in the data comes from the elections held in 2017, 2022, and 1993. Figure C.3 shows that the districts included in the sample - where a female or male candidate was within 3 percentage points of the cutoff - span

Figure 1: Examples of running variable construction

(a) Department 14 district 3, election-year 2022



(b) Department 33 district 6, election-year 2017



Notes. The two examples show the electoral results for the four most-voted candidates in two different electoral districts. In the case of Panel (a), two observations are included in the analysis, while in the case of Panel (b), only one observation is included.

the French territory, and neither males nor females are concentrated in a specific geographic area.

4.1 Internal validity

The validity of the RDD relies on the assumption that first-round candidates of a particular type (e.g., males) do not systematically sort on the right of the qualification threshold. Such manipulation is unlikely since France is a democracy, and international observers qualify the elections as pluralistic, competitive, and

respectful of fundamental rights.[12] In addition, manipulation is difficult because it requires predicting the outcome of the first election stage with great accuracy. I test the assumption's validity using the Cattaneo, Jansson, and Ma (2018) test and check whether the density of the running variable jumps at the threshold. As Figure C.4 in the Appendix demonstrates, there is no jump at the margin.

Another implication of the identifying assumption is that districts' characteristics are continuous at the threshold. I run balancing tests for turnout, number of candidates, number of female candidates, number of enrolled voters, whether a woman was elected in the past, gender wage gap, number of candidates per ideology, and sum of vote share per ideology. Table C12 in the Appendix shows sharp RDD estimates of the effect of having a woman in the second-round, rather than a man, on first-round electoral district characteristics. Of the 18 regressions, the coefficient on the treatment variable is statistically significant only for the number of enrolled voters at the 5 percent. Reassuringly, the main results are similar when controlling for this covariate (Appendix Table D20). I also run a general balance test to check whether being a female candidate versus a male candidate jumps at the threshold. To predict treatment status, I regress treatment status on all the district covariates referred and in Table C12. As shown in Appendix Table C13 and Figure C.5, the predicted probability of being a female candidate does not jump at the qualification threshold.

I also test for a jump in several individual characteristics. Marshall (2024) notes that politician regression discontinuity designs identify the effect of the predetermined characteristic and all compensating differentials. I run balancing tests for several individual characteristics (Appendix Table C14): vote share in the first-round, victory margin between the candidate and the opponent in the second-round, incumbent, ran in the past, occupation (out of labor force, low-skilled, middle-skilled, high-skilled), age groups, and ideology (far-left, left, liberal, right, far-right, other). Only one out of the 20 individual characteristics is statistically significant: right, at 10 percent. As a robustness check, I run a separate regression discontinuity analysis in which I focus on male candidates and compare how right-wing vs non-right-wing candidates adjust between rounds; I do not find significant differences in the adjustment of female- and male-stereotyped topics, and the adjustment is close to zero (Appendix Table C16). I also run a heterogeneity analysis in Tables D18 and D22. Finally, I also confirm the robustness of the results to controlling for ideology (see Tables D19 and D22).

Di Tella et al. (2025) show empirically that candidates strategically adjust their

[12] *France. Presidential Election 10 and 24 April 2022. ODIHR Election Assessment Mission Final Report* (2022).

platforms to move closer to their opponents. The results may be confounded because female candidates' opponents are mostly from a specific ideology. In Table C15, I present balancing tests on opponents' ideology and find that they are balanced.

An interesting question is whether women and men already differed in first-round topic salience or campaigning style. Tables 1 shows no significant differences, since the values are close to zero and nonsignificant. Table 2 shows that female candidates use less agentic language in the first-round, although only significant at 10 percent. In addition, women use less communal language than men in general by 6 percentage points (significant at 0.1 percent), and also by topic. The direction may appear surprising, since warmth is the register stereotypically associated with women. However, this is what a compensation account predicts: voters already attribute warmth to female candidates, so adding more of it adds little and risks substituting warmth for competence. Women prefer to use more neutral language.

Table 1: Differences in topics salience between female and male candidates in the first round

	(1) Female-stereotyped	(2) Male-stereotyped	(3) Other
Woman	0.010	0.025	0.002
	(0.029)	(0.043)	(0.029)
Observations	798	798	798
Eff. number of obs	288	370	305
Robust p-value	0.790	0.437	0.840
Polyn. order	1	1	1
Bandwidth	2.691	3.584	2.901
Mean, left of threshold	0.126	0.106	0.886

Standard errors in parentheses are clustered at the district-year level. Each column reports the results from a separate local polynomial regression. The variable of interest is being a woman rather than a man. Separate polynomials are fitted on each side of the threshold. The polynomial order is 1, and the optimal bandwidths are derived under the MSERD procedure. The dependent variables take values between 0 and 1, and their computation is explained in Section 3.3.1. The mean gives the average outcome value for male candidates at the threshold.

Endogenous sample selection can also affect the analysis. Although some candidates are eligible for the second-round, they decide not to run; this constitutes only 0.8% of cases, and column 1 of Table C17 shows that female politicians are no more likely than males to give up on going to the second-round. Another concern is whether one gender is more likely to have a political platform observed than the

Table 2: Differences in campaigning style between female and male candidates in the first round

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
	Panel A: Agentic style			
	Agentic	Female-stereotyped	Male-stereotyped	Other
Woman	-0.043	-0.027	0.034	-0.032
	(0.024)	(0.050)	(0.043)	(0.021)
Observations	798	798	798	798
Eff. number of obs	400	271	243	329
Robust p-value	0.088	0.679	0.290	0.097
Polyn. order	1	1	1	1
Bandwidth	3.962	2.541	2.172	3.100
Mean, left of threshold	0.133	0.081	0.026	0.080
	Panel B: Communal style			
	Communal	Female-stereotyped	Male-stereotyped	Other
Woman	-0.060	-0.060	-0.024	-0.043
	(0.019)	(0.021)	(0.013)	(0.019)
Observations	798	798	798	798
Eff. number of obs	320	261	218	332
Robust p-value	0.001	0.002	0.037	0.022
Polyn. order	1	1	1	1
Bandwidth	3.025	2.360	1.901	3.107
Mean, left of threshold	0.100	0.052	0.018	0.086

Standard errors in parenthesis are clustered at the district-candidate level. Each column reports the results from a separate local polynomial regression. The variable of interest is being a woman rather than a man. Separate polynomials are fitted on each side of the threshold. The polynomial order is 1, and the optimal bandwidths are derived under the MSERD procedure. The computation of the dependent variables is explained in Section 3.3.2. The mean gives the average outcome value for male candidates at the threshold.

other. Column 2 of Table C17 shows that this is not the case; there is no significant jump in the probability of having both manifestos available at the qualification threshold.

5 Results: Gender differences in political platforms

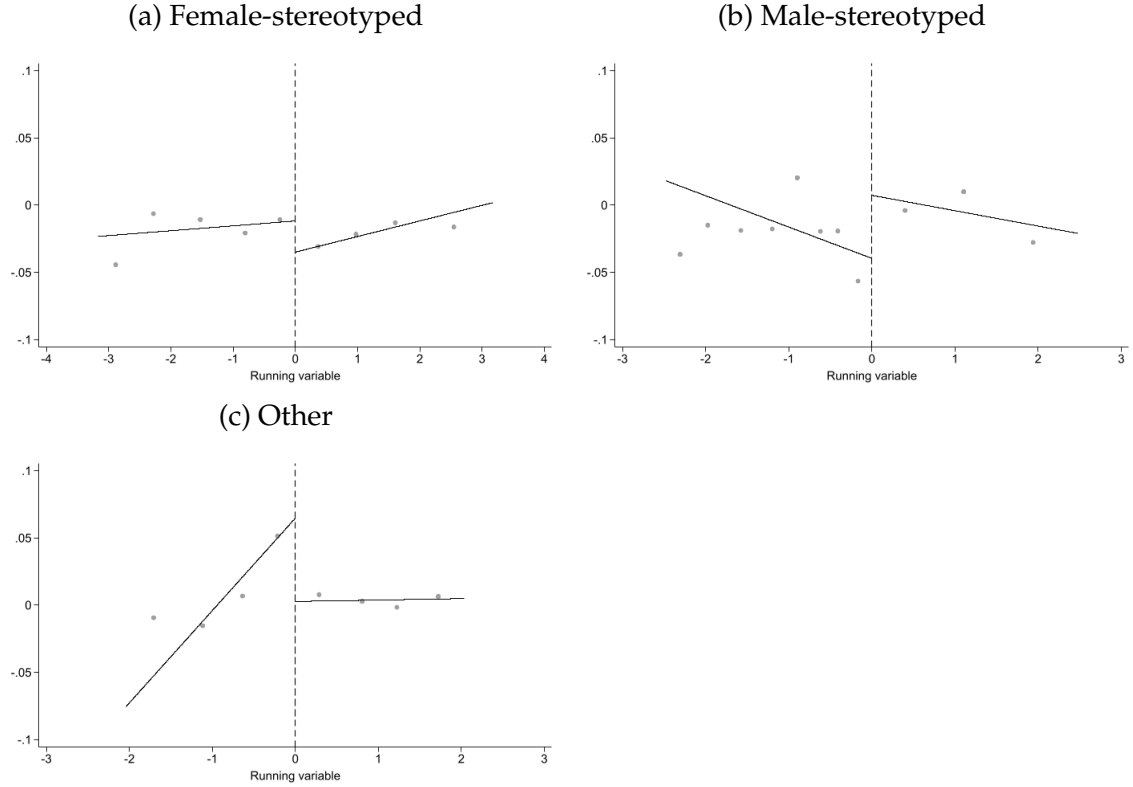
5.1 Topics

In this section, I use the empirical strategy described above to examine gender differences in how politicians adjust topic salience between the first and second-rounds. I examine the adjustment in three ways: female-stereotyped topics (health and education), male-stereotyped topics (justice and immigration), and other top-

ics (the remaining topics).

Figure 2 shows the largest jump in male-stereotyped topics. For the remaining topics, coverage appears to drop slightly. In the figure, each dot represents the average outcome within a given bin of the running variable - that is, the vote share difference between the most-voted woman and the most-voted man in the first-round (excluding the opponent).

Figure 2: Gender differences in topics adjustment between 1st and 2nd round



Notes. Each graph is constructed by restricting the support to observations within the estimation bandwidths and fitting a local polynomial point estimator (polynomial order 1 and triangular kernel). Dots represent the local averages of the outcome (vertical axis). Averages are calculated within quantile bins of the running variable (horizontal axis). The outcome is the change in topic coverage from the first to the second-round. The running variable is the vote share difference between the most-voted woman and the most-voted man, excluding the opponent in the second round.

Table 3 complements the graphical analysis and provides the formal estimates of the effects. Panel A aggregates the eleven topics into three groups: female-stereotyped topics (health and education), male-stereotyped topics (justice and criminality, and immigration), and the remaining topics. Panel B reports the individual topics that compose the three groups. As Panel A shows, between the first and second-round, women write 2.3 percentage points less about female-stereotyped topics (not statistically significant) and 4.7 percentage points more

about male-stereotyped topics than men ($p = 0.057$). Candidates have a two-page limit for their platforms, and as a consequence this increase might come at the cost of less coverage of other topics. This is indeed what column (3) shows: women decrease the coverage of other topics by 6.2 percentage points. Panel B shows how these aggregates decompose. Within male-stereotyped topics, the increase is mostly driven by immigration. Within female-stereotyped topics, the reduction is concentrated in health (-2.6 percentage points, robust $p = 0.033$), while the change in education is near zero.

Table 3: Gender differences in topics adjustment between 1st and 2nd round

Panel A: Aggregated topic groups

	(1) Female-stereotyped	(2) Male-stereotyped	(3) Other
Woman	-0.023	0.047	-0.062
	(0.017)	(0.024)	(0.029)
Robust p-value	0.187	0.057	0.025
Observations	798	798	798
Eff. number of obs	334	266	232
Polyn. order	1	1	1
Bandwidth	3.166	2.474	2.039
Mean, left of threshold	-0.012	-0.040	0.065

Panel B: Individual topics

	(1) Health	(2) Education	(3) Justice	(4) Immigration	(5) Local	(6) National	(7) Other policy
Woman	-0.026	0.002	0.016	0.049	0.016	-0.062	0.029
	(0.013)	(0.012)	(0.015)	(0.034)	(0.020)	(0.053)	(0.050)
Robust p-value	0.033	0.767	0.379	0.113	0.594	0.208	0.446
Observations	798	798	798	798	798	798	798
Eff. number of obs	263	375	320	263	369	309	344
Polyn. order	1	1	1	1	1	1	1
Bandwidth	2.424	3.663	3.027	2.408	3.579	2.924	3.257
Mean, left of threshold	0.003	-0.021	-0.013	-0.045	-0.006	0.114	-0.049

Notes: Standard errors in parentheses are clustered at the district-year level. Each column reports the results from a separate local polynomial regression. The variable of interest is being a woman rather than a man. Separate polynomials are fitted on each side of the threshold. The polynomial order is 1, and the optimal bandwidths are derived under the MSERD procedure. Coefficients are conventional local polynomial estimates; standard errors, confidence intervals, and p-values are robust bias-corrected following Calonico et al. (2014). The dependent variables take values between 0 and 1, and their computation is explained in Section 3.3.1. The mean gives the average outcome value for male candidates at the threshold.

Robustness To further support the identification strategy, I conduct several robustness checks. The results are similar when I test the covariate-adjusted version (Calonico et al. (2019)); see Appendix Table D21. I also show the robustness of the results to a wide range of bandwidths (Appendix Table D.6). I also present jackknife estimates excluding one candidate at a time to ensure that the results

are not driven by a subset of observations near the cutoff and show that the point estimates remain very similar (Appendix Table D.7).

5.2 Campaigning style: Agentic vs communal

The content of a campaign is only part of what a candidate communicates. Alongside the issues a platform raises, it conveys a manner of self-presentation: whether the candidate appears as someone who decides, acts and obtains results, or as someone who listens, is close to constituents and acts with them. Social psychology has long organized impressions of individuals along these two dimensions, labelled agency and communion (Abele & Wojciszke, 2007; Bakan, 1966), and they are dimensions on which gender stereotypes are sharply defined: men are expected to be assertive, competitive and decisive, women to be warm, caring and relationship-oriented.

In Table 4 I present the results for the campaigning style. Panel A shows no change in agentic language, either in the platform as a whole or within any topic group; none of the four estimates approaches significance. Panel B shows a clear change in communal language: relative to male candidates, female candidates increase the share of their platform written in a communal register by 4.2 percentage points between the first and the second-round (robust $p = 0.003$).

The magnitudes are informative. The increase is almost exactly the size of the first-round shortfall, so that by the second-round the difference in communal language between female and male candidates has essentially disappeared. This is consistent with the change in what the contest requires. The first-round rewards establishing standing in a crowded field, where being taken seriously is the binding constraint; the second requires assembling a majority from an electorate that includes the supporters of eliminated candidates, where likeability becomes consequential and where the credibility that suppression protected has already been demonstrated by qualifying.

Robustness To further support the identification strategy, I conduct several robustness checks. The results are similar when I test the covariate-adjusted version (Calonico et al. (2019)); see Appendix Table D25. I also show the robustness of the results to a wide range of bandwidths (Appendix Table D.8). I also present jackknife estimates excluding one candidate at a time to ensure that the results are not driven by a subset of observations near the cutoff and show that the point estimates remain very similar (Appendix Table D.9).

Table 4: Differences between how female and male candidates adjust their campaigns between the 1st and 2nd round in terms of agentic vs communal language

Panel A: Agentic language

	(1) Overall	(2) Female-stereotyped	(3) Male-stereotyped	(4) Other
Woman	0.005	0.004	-0.002	0.005
	(0.017)	(0.028)	(0.035)	(0.016)
Robust p-value	0.746	0.864	0.909	0.666
Observations	798	798	798	798
Eff. number of obs	335	267	262	290
Polyn. order	1	1	1	1
Bandwidth	3.192	2.514	2.383	2.736
Mean, left of threshold	-0.004	0.007	0.013	0.005

Panel B: Communal language

	(1) Overall	(2) Female-stereotyped	(3) Male-stereotyped	(4) Other
Woman	0.048	0.004	0.038	0.026
	(0.014)	(0.015)	(0.016)	(0.011)
Robust p-value	0.001	0.656	0.017	0.029
Observations	798	798	798	798
Eff. number of obs	280	346	224	370
Polyn. order	1	1	1	1
Bandwidth	2.628	3.298	1.981	3.588
Mean, left of threshold	-0.016	-0.003	-0.025	-0.006

Notes: The outcome is the change between the first- and second-round platforms in the share of segments written in an agentic register (Panel A) or in a communal register (Panel B); their construction is explained in Section 3.3.2. Column (1) uses all segments of the platform; columns (2) to (4) restrict attention to the segments classified in each topic group, so that the measure is the register used within that content and is not mechanically affected by changes in topic salience. Each column reports the results from a separate local polynomial regression. The variable of interest is being a woman rather than a man. Separate polynomials are fitted on each side of the threshold. The polynomial order is 1, and the optimal bandwidths are derived under the MSERD procedure. Coefficients are conventional local polynomial estimates; standard errors, clustered at the district-year level, are in parentheses, and p-values are robust bias-corrected following Calonico et al. (2014). The mean gives the average outcome value for male candidates at the threshold.

6 Mechanisms

6.1 Who is adjusting? Female or male candidates?

In Section 5.1, the regression discontinuity estimates identify the difference in the adjustment between rounds between female and male candidates. The results may be driven by women increasing the prevalence of a topic, men decreasing it, or both. To address this question, I estimate the average change in topic salience at the

cutoff separately for men and women who barely qualified for the second-round, using local linear regressions with a triangular kernel and the same MSE-optimal bandwidth on both sides of the threshold. Table 5 reports the results.

Male candidates drive the gender gap in male-stereotyped topics. Between the first and second-rounds, men who barely qualified reduce the salience of male-stereotyped topics by 4.0 percentage points ($p < 0.05$), whereas women leave the salience of these topics essentially unchanged. The resulting 4.7 percentage-point difference is therefore explained by men moving away from these topics rather than by women moving toward them. The salience men lose appears to be reallocated to topics that are not gender-stereotyped: men increase the salience of the remaining topics by 6.5 percentage points ($p < 0.05$), while women's emphasis on these topics does not change.

The pattern for female-stereotyped topics differs. Women who barely qualified reduce the salience of these topics by 3.5 percentage points ($p < 0.01$), while the change for men is small and not statistically significant (-1.2 percentage points). However, the difference between women and men (-2.3 percentage points) is not statistically significant, so we cannot conclude that women retreat from female-stereotyped topics more than men do.

Panel B confirms no adjustment in terms of agentic language. Panel C shows that, between the first and second-round, women increase the use of communal language overall, and this change is driven by the non-stereotyped topics. In contrast, men decrease their use of male-stereotyped topics and do so with less communal language.

6.2 Do candidates strategically adapt to the gender of their opponent?

I focus on runoffs with exactly two candidates. Each finalist campaigns against an opponent whose gender is itself a feature of the race. A mixed-gender runoff makes gender salient in a way that a same-gender runoff does not, so the constraints on how women may campaign should bind most when the opponent is a man. Two bodies of work give competing predictions about what should happen.

The first is role congruity theory (Eagly & Karau, 2002), which holds that prejudice against female leaders arises from the perceived incongruity between the female gender role and the leader role and is activated when gender becomes salient. A mixed-gender runoff makes gender salient in a way a same-gender runoff does not, so constraints on how a woman may campaign should bind most when her opponent is a man. Work on self-stereotyping points the same way: Coffman (2014)

Table 5: Between-round change in topic salience and rhetorical register at the cutoff, by candidate gender

Panel A: Topic salience				
		Female-stereotyped	Male-stereotyped	Other
Men: average change		-0.012	-0.040**	0.065***
		(0.012)	(0.020)	(0.021)
Women: average change		-0.035***	0.007	0.003
		(0.012)	(0.014)	(0.019)
Difference (women – men)		-0.023	0.047*	-0.062**
		(0.017)	(0.024)	(0.029)
Bandwidth		3.166	2.474	2.039
Eff. obs. (men / women)		177 / 157	131 / 135	112 / 120
Panel B: Agentic language				
	Overall	Female-stereotyped	Male-stereotyped	Other
Men: average change	-0.004	-0.003	0.001	0.007
	(0.013)	(0.004)	(0.003)	(0.011)
Women: average change	0.001	-0.004	0.007	0.011
	(0.010)	(0.004)	(0.005)	(0.010)
Difference (women – men)	0.005	-0.001	0.006	0.004
	(0.017)	(0.005)	(0.006)	(0.015)
Bandwidth	3.192	3.300	1.878	2.740
Eff. obs. (men / women)	178 / 157	185 / 163	101 / 111	149 / 141
Panel C: Communal language				
	Overall	Female-stereotyped	Male-stereotyped	Other
Men: average change	-0.016	-0.002	-0.003*	-0.004
	(0.010)	(0.002)	(0.002)	(0.008)
Women: average change	0.033***	0.001	0.001	0.019***
	(0.009)	(0.001)	(0.002)	(0.007)
Difference (women – men)	0.048***	0.003	0.004	0.023**
	(0.014)	(0.002)	(0.003)	(0.010)
Bandwidth	2.628	3.738	3.175	3.731
Eff. obs. (men / women)	142 / 138	198 / 180	177 / 157	198 / 178

Notes: Panel A reports the change between the first- and second-round platforms in the share of each topic group: female-stereotyped (health and education), male-stereotyped (justice and criminality, and immigration) and the remaining topics. Panels B and C report the change in the share of segments written in an agentic and in a communal register, respectively, for the platform as a whole and within the segments assigned to each topic group; measured within a topic group, the register is not mechanically affected by changes in topic salience. The rows *Men* and *Women* report the average change at the cutoff for male and female candidates who barely qualified for the second-round, estimated by local linear regression with a triangular kernel and separate slopes on each side of the cutoff. Each column uses its own MSE-optimal bandwidth, common to both sides of the cutoff, so men and women are compared within the same window and the entries of a panel need not add up across columns. The difference is the conventional RD estimate. Only the differences are causally identified; the averages by candidate gender are conditional means at the threshold. Standard errors clustered by district-year in parentheses. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

shows that individuals are less willing to put their ideas forward in domains incongruent with their gender, and that this reflects beliefs about their own ability rather than ability itself, while Bordalo et al. (2019) show that such beliefs respond to the composition of the relevant comparison. On this account, the adjustment for female candidates should vary with the opponent's gender.

The second is the literature on issue emphasis and issue ownership (Aragonès, Castanheira, & Giani, 2015; Petrocik, 1996), which holds that candidates compete less by taking opposing positions on the same issues than by making different issues salient, and that emphasis is valuable only insofar as it distinguishes a candidate from the opponent. On this account, the candidate's behavior should vary with the opponent's gender when the opponent owns the gendered terrain at stake.

Table 6 re-estimates the analysis separately for races where the second-round opponent is a man and races where the opponent is a woman, using the heterogeneity estimator from Calonico, Cattaneo, Farrell, Palomba, and Titiunik (2025). The evidence favors the second account. The gender gap in male-stereotyped topics is concentrated in all-male runoffs: it is 8.2 percentage points when the opponent is a man (robust $p = 0.033$) and essentially zero when the opponent is a woman, and the two are statistically distinguishable ($p = 0.032$). The same contrast appears, with the opposite sign, for the remaining topics (-10.0 against a man, -1.9 against a woman, $p = 0.045$). For female-stereotyped topics, the two estimates are almost identical ($p = 0.871$).

This is what differentiation implies. Against another man, justice and immigration distinguish neither candidate: both are presumed competent on them, so emphasizing them buys nothing, and the space is better used to broaden the platform's appeal as the electorate widens between rounds (Le Pennec, 2023). Male candidates, in short, broaden when nothing differentiates them and retain their stereotypical advantage when something does.

The role congruity prediction does not hold for women: female candidates neither retreat from masculine terrain against a man, which would concede the dimension entirely, nor gain by emphasizing it against another woman, and their adjustment is unchanged by whom they face.

6.3 Gender differences and electoral competitiveness

Experimental research shows that men and women respond differently to performance feedback in competitive environments (Berlin and Dargnies (2016)). Providing relative performance feedback allows to reduce gender differences in compet-

Table 6: Differences in campaign adjustment between female and male candidates depending on the gender of the second-round opponent

	Topic salience						Rhetorical register			
	Female-stereotyped		Male-stereotyped		Other		Agentic		Communal	
Opponent	Male	Female	Male	Female	Male	Female	Male	Female	Male	Female
Woman	-0.026	-0.019	0.082**	-0.004	-0.100**	-0.019	0.010	-0.008	0.049***	0.036**
	(0.489)	(0.329)	(0.033)	(0.643)	(0.028)	(0.898)	(0.561)	(0.603)	(0.009)	(0.033)
P-value (male)=(female)	0.871		0.032		0.045		0.899		0.849	
Observations	531	267	531	267	531	267	531	267	531	267
Eff. number of obs.	201	116	167	89	142	114	216	126	189	129
Polyn. order	1	1	1	1	1	1	1	1	1	1
Bandwidth	2.967	3.076	2.286	2.450	1.976	3.033	3.141	3.316	2.763	3.387
Mean, left of threshold	-0.017	-0.004	-0.074	0.006	0.092	0.031	0.000	-0.009	-0.016	-0.009

Notes: The dependent variables take values between 0 and 1, and their computation is explained in Section 3.3.1. The variable of interest is being a woman rather than a man. Separate polynomials are fitted on each side of the threshold. The polynomial order is 1, and the optimal bandwidths are derived under the MSERD procedure. The heterogeneity analysis is performed following Calonico et al. (2025). The mean gives the average outcome value for male candidates at the threshold.

itive choices (Wozniak, Harbaugh, and Mayr (2014), Baier, Davis, and Jaber-Lopez (2024)). Given the quasi-experimental nature of French legislative elections, first-round electoral results can serve as relative performance feedback for candidates.

To test whether a candidate's position in the race matters for adjustment, Table 7 exploits heterogeneity in victory margins. I define victory margin as the difference in the vote shares in the first-round between the candidate and the opponent in the second-round. In Panel A, I treat victory margin as a discrete variable and split the analysis into candidates whose victory margin is below the median and those whose victory margin is above the median. I conclude that the results are driven by candidates with victory margins below the median, that is, those clearly behind their opponents. When candidates are at a disadvantage relative to their opponents, the gender gap in male-stereotyped topics increases by 9.8 percentage points. When the victory margin is above the median, female candidates do not differ from male candidates on any topic or communication style. In Panel B, I use victory margin as a continuous variable, which summarizes the heterogeneity analysis. When women obtained the same share of votes as their opponents in the first-round, there are no significant differences. Each additional point of first-round disadvantage is associated with a 1.4 percentage-point increase in male-stereotyped topics. The conclusion is similar to the use of communal language; when women obtained the same share of votes as their opponents in the first-round, they did not adjust the use of communal language; each additional point of first-round disadvantage is associated with a 0.7 percentage-point increase in communal language. In the Appendix, Table E26 shows the same pattern for health: female candidates decrease the prevalence of health when they are at a disadvan-

tage relative to their opponent.

Table 7: Differences in topics adjustment between female and male candidates - Heterogeneity by victory margin in the 1st round between the candidate and the opponent

	Female-stereotyped		Male-stereotyped		Other		Agentic		Communal	
	Below	Above	Below	Above	Below	Above	Below	Above	Below	Above
Panel A: Heterogeneity with discretized victory margin										
Woman	-0.014	-0.032	0.098	0.004	-0.107	-0.015	0.001	0.025	0.075	0.020
	(0.026)	(0.046)	(0.078)	(0.038)	(0.071)	(0.048)	(0.049)	(0.039)	(0.030)	(0.028)
P-value (below)=(above)	0.910		0.023		0.186		0.751		0.072	
Observations	399	399	399	399	399	399	399	399	399	399
Eff. number of obs	191	155	127	132	106	177	125	148	149	147
Robust p-value	0.268	0.629	0.018	0.730	0.035	0.451	0.388	0.559	0.001	0.290
Polyn. order	1	1	1	1	1	1	1	1	1	1
Bandwidth	3.768	3.013	2.301	2.338	1.871	3.329	2.254	2.871	2.844	2.814
Mean, left of threshold	-0.023	-0.001	-0.077	-0.011	0.103	0.026	-0.007	-0.012	-0.035	0.003
Panel B: Heterogeneity with linear victory margin										
Woman at zero margin	-0.021		-0.051		0.010		0.019		-0.002	
	(0.045)		(0.054)		(0.068)		(0.038)		(0.031)	
Robust p-value	0.498		0.111		0.895		0.803		0.554	
Woman # victory margin	0.001		-0.014		0.010		0.002		-0.007	
	(0.004)		(0.007)		(0.007)		(0.004)		(0.004)	
Robust p-value	0.980		0.004		0.045		0.639		0.090	
Polyn. order	1		1		1		1		1	
Bandwidth	3.174		2.486		2.047		3.203		2.637	
Eff. number of obs	668		532		464		674		562	
Observations	798		798		798		798		798	

Victory margin is the difference between the share of votes the candidate received in the first round and the opponent's share in the second-round. In Panel A, Below refers to candidates whose victory margin is below the median, while Above refers to candidates whose victory margin is above the median. In Panel B, victory margin is a continuous variable. Standard errors in parentheses are clustered at the district-year level. Each column reports the results from a separate local polynomial regression. The variable of interest is being a woman rather than a man. Separate polynomials are fitted on each side of the threshold. The polynomial order is 1, and the optimal bandwidths are derived under the MSERD procedure. The heterogeneity analysis is performed following Calonico et al. (2025). The dependent variables take values between 0 and 1, and their computation is explained in Section 3.3.1. The mean gives the average outcome value for male candidates at the threshold.

6.4 Electoral outcomes

The results establish that between the first and second-round, male candidates reduce the prevalence of male-stereotyped topics and female candidates increase the use of communal language. A natural next question is whether this difference matters electorally: does adjusting the salience of gender-stereotyped topics affect the votes a candidate receives in the second-round?

Answering this question requires care. The discontinuity design identifies the effect of a female candidate, rather than a male candidate qualifying for the runoff, on both the candidate's platform and her vote share, but it does not identify the effect of the platform on vote share. To address this challenge, I follow Acharya et al. (2016) and estimate the average controlled direct effect (ACDE): the causal effect

of a treatment (gender) after accounting for the effect of the mediator (campaign adjustment between rounds).

The ACDE is estimated by sequential g-estimation. First, the outcome (the share of votes in the second-round) is regressed on the treatment, the measure of topic adjustment, pre-treatment covariates, and any intermediate confounders; the estimated effect of the adjustment is then subtracted from the outcome.[13] In a second stage, the demediated outcome is regressed on the treatment and pre-treatment covariates alone. Standard errors are obtained by a block bootstrap at the district-year level, which accounts for the fact that the demediated outcome depends on a first-stage estimate.[14]

Two assumptions are required. The first, that candidate gender is as good as randomly assigned near the threshold, is delivered by the discontinuity design. The second is that the between-round adjustment is as good as random, conditional on candidate gender, pre-treatment covariates, and intermediate confounders.

Table 8 reports the results. Panel A shows no gender gap in votes, and between-round adjustments account for none of the difference in electoral performance between male and female candidates. The total effect of a woman rather than a man qualifying for the runoff on second-round vote share is small and statistically insignificant (0.010 percentage points, standard error 0.006), and fixing both topic adjustments at zero for all candidates leaves it essentially unchanged (0.008, standard error 0.006). The difference between the two, 0.002 points, is not statistically distinguishable from zero.

Panel B shows why: the adjustments themselves have no detectable effect on vote share. A one-percentage-point increase in the salience of male-stereotyped topics changes a female candidate's second-round vote share by 0.018 points (not significant), and the corresponding effect for female-stereotyped topics is also small. The effects do not differ appreciably between male and female candidates, so there is no evidence that voters reward or penalize the same adjustment differently by gender.

The absence of electoral returns is informative about the behavior documented in this paper. If candidates adjusted their platforms to maximize votes, they would concentrate adjustment where it pays off. Instead, male and female candidates adjust along gender lines, even though the adjustment has no detectable effect on

[13] Intermediate confounders are variables that are affected by the treatment and affect both the mediator and outcome. I do not include any intermediate confounders, since all the potential controls are pre-treatment.

[14] All estimates use the MSE-optimal bandwidth for second-round vote share (Calonico et al., 2014), held fixed across bootstrap replications.

their electoral performance. This pattern is more consistent with candidates acting on shared expectations about how men and women are supposed to campaign than with a vote-maximizing strategy that exploits differences in how voters evaluate male and female candidates.

Table 8: Electoral consequences of between-round platform adjustment

	(1) Female-stereotyped	(2) Male-stereotyped	(3) Agentic	(4) Communal
Panel A: Gender gap in 2nd round vote share				
Total effect		0.010		
		(0.006)		
Controlled direct effect		0.008		
		(0.006)		
Difference		0.002		
		(0.002)		
Panel B: Effect of adjustment on 2nd round vote share				
Female candidates	-0.056	0.018	0.007	0.013
	(0.048)	(0.027)	(0.035)	(0.047)
Male candidates	-0.035	0.008	0.051	0.000
	(0.041)	(0.023)	(0.035)	(0.051)
Observations		372		
Bandwidth		3.077		

Notes: Estimates from sequential g-estimation (Acharya et al., 2016), using local linear regressions with a triangular kernel and the MSE-optimal bandwidth for second-round vote share. The outcome is the second-round vote share and the mediators are the between-round changes in the salience of female- and male-stereotyped topics and in the use of agentic and communal language, all measured as shares between 0 and 1. The four mediators come from a single model in which they enter jointly: non-gendered topics are the omitted category for the two topic mediators, and agency and communion enter separately because they are distinct dimensions rather than poles of one scale. The first stage regresses the outcome on the treatment, the mediators, their interactions with the treatment, and pre-treatment covariates, including the first-round value of each mediator. The second stage regresses the demediated outcome on the treatment and pre-treatment covariates only. Panel A compares the total effect with the controlled direct effect, which fixes the four adjustments at zero for all candidates. Panel B reports the effect on vote share of a one-unit change in each adjustment. In Panels A and B, standard errors in parentheses are from 1,000 cluster-bootstrap replications at the district-year level, and significance stars use a normal approximation. $^{*}\ p < 0.10$, $^{**}\ p < 0.05$, $^{***}\ p < 0.01$.

6.5 Discussion of alternative mechanisms

The evidence presented above is consistent with men adjusting to broaden the topics discussed in the second-round. I now discuss alternative interpretations for the findings.

Differences in policy preferences Gender differences in campaigns could simply reflect gender differences in policy preferences, meaning that female candidates might decide to decrease the salience of health topics because they give less value to them. However, this rationality is against the findings of the literature on elected women. Lippmann (2022) finds that female elected politicians are more active on women's issues while men on military issues. Similarly, Baskaran and

Hessami (2025) conclude that female councilors promote the expansion of public child care. Hessami and da Fonseca (2020) provide a literature review on female political representation and effects on policies, and report no significant differences in public spending. Even if in the specific context of French legislative elections, female candidates have a preference for policies related to justice & criminality and immigration, why did they do not reveal their preferences in the first-round? Table 1 shows no significant differences, with the effects very close to zero.

Differences in campaign donations If campaign funds are essential to a politician's success, then large differences in how much money male and female candidates raise might affect how women and men campaign in their races. Previous research has causally shown a gender gap in campaign fundraising for US state legislators (Barber et al. (2016)) and Brazilian mayoral candidates (Brollo and Troiano (2016)). I exploit differences in contributions from the party, donors, or personal resources to disentangle party and donor discrimination from differences in personal resources. In Table E27, I show no significant differences between female and male candidates in any campaign resource. These results have several implications. First, the lack of differences in total expenditures or revenues implies that women are not more or less financially constrained. Second, personal contributions are also a proxy for financial risk-aversion, and the lack of significant differences suggests that gender differences in risk-aversion are unlikely to explain the results. Third, no significant differences in party contributions show that parties do not treat female and male candidates differently. Fourth, donors do not seem to discriminate between female and male candidates, although the sources might differ and such information is unavailable.

Candidates are just responding to the opponents The results may simply reflect that candidates respond to their opponents or converge on their behavior. Table E28 shows that during the first-round, the opponents of female and male candidates did not address different topics in their campaigns, nor did they campaign in a more agentic or communal style; all results are far from being statistically significant. In addition, between the first and second-round, candidates do not adjust their campaigns.

Candidates adjust to the gender of absent candidates The RDD compares female candidates who barely qualified for the second-round (while a male candidate narrowly failed to qualify in that electoral district) with male candidates who barely qualified (while a female candidate narrowly failed to qualify). The treatment therefore bundles the finalist's gender with the gender of the candidate who was narrowly eliminated. If the eliminated candidate's identity matters, both female and male finalists may respond to having narrowly beaten a candidate of

the opposite gender. For example, if female candidates ran in the first-round but only male candidates remained in the second, male finalists might try to attract the eliminated female candidate's voters by downplaying male-stereotyped topics.

I examine whether the effects vary with the electoral weight of the eliminated female candidates. I measure it as the sum of the first-round vote shares, expressed as a percentage of registered voters, of all female candidates in the electoral district who did not advance to the second round. Because the number of female candidates, and hence their combined vote share, increased substantially over the period, particularly after the 2000 parity law, I demean this variable by election year. Thus, it captures whether eliminated female candidates were electorally stronger than in other districts in the same election, rather than differences across election years. If finalists court the voters of eliminated women, the adjustment should be stronger where these voters are more numerous.

Table E29 reports the results. The Woman row gives the effect at the election-year mean of the moderator, and the interaction term gives how the effect changes with each additional percentage point of the vote share of eliminated women. None of the interaction terms is statistically significant. I therefore find no evidence that finalists tailor their programs to the voters of eliminated female candidates.

7 Conclusion

Using individual campaign platforms covering all French legislative elections from 1981 to 2024, I provide the first causal evidence of gender differences in campaign strategies. The two-round electoral system enables a regression discontinuity design that compares female candidates who barely qualify for the second-round with male candidates in nearly identical electoral environments. While during the first-round of the campaign, female and male candidates do not differ on the issues discussed, gender differences emerge during the second-round of the political campaign. I find that between the first and second-round, the gender gap in male-stereotyped topics increases by 4.7 percentage points. This adjustment stems from men reducing the prevalence of these topics, and this adjustment is significant only when their opponent is a man. I interpret this result as evidence of platform differentiation rather than conformity with the role congruity theory.

The paper also explores gender differences in campaign style, specifically, agentic and communal language. Agentic language lets candidates present themselves as leaders and results-driven, while communal language positions them as willing to listen and close to their constituents. I find that in the first-round, women use less agentic and communal language in their campaigns than men, but in the

runoff, they close the gap in terms of communal language.

These results have implications for how we think about political representation. Most of what we know about gender and politics concerns elected officials: what they legislate, how they allocate budgets, and whether their presence encourages other women to run. The evidence here points to a margin that operates earlier. Because the issues a campaign makes salient help determine the terms of an election, the gender composition of a race shapes political debate even when no woman is ultimately elected. A parity law or a candidate selection rule that changes who competes therefore changes campaign content, independently of whether it changes who wins.

The paper opens several avenues for research. First, we need to better understand the beliefs that drive politicians' behavior. This paper infers them from choices and the absence of electoral returns; we need further evidence on what candidates believe voters reward, and what voters reward by gender. Such evidence would let us distinguish anticipating a penalty from norms irrespective of the penalty. Second, while this paper concludes that in the first-round female and male candidates do not significantly differ in campaign content, and that the differences that emerge in the second-round are driven either by strategic behavior or norms, Lippmann (2022) finds that elected female politicians are most active on women's issues while men are involved in military issues. We need to better understand whether a politician's campaign behavior lets voters predict their behavior once elected, or whether elected politicians' behavior is also driven by peers and party constraints.

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Appendix

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A Institutional context

I assign candidates to seven political orientations (far-left, left, liberal, right, far-right, and other). I use the party classifications from the Chapel Hill Expert Survey (CHES) and, when missing, from the ParlGov and Granzier et al. (2023). I measure party positioning on a scale from 0 (left) to 1 (right) and include family classification.

1981 Parliamentary Elections	
Political label	**Political orientation**
Parti Communiste Français	Far-left
Divers Droite	Right
Divers Gauche	Left
Ecologistes	Left
Extrême Droite	Far-right
Extrême Gauche	Far-left
Indépendants	Other
Non Classés	Other
Rassemblement pour la République	Right
Socialistes	Left
Union pour la Démocratie Française	Right

1988 Parliamentary Elections	
Political label	**Political orientation**
Parti Communiste Français	Far-left
Divers Droite	Right
Ecologistes	Left
Extrême Droite	Far-right
Extrême Gauche	Far-left
Front National	Far-right
Majorité Présidentielle	Left
Radicaux de Gauche	Left
Régionalistes	Other
Rassemblement pour la République	Right
Socialistes	Left
Union pour la Démocratie Française	Right

1993 Parliamentary Elections	
Political label	**Political orientation**
Parti Communiste Français	Far-left
Divers	Other
Divers Droite	Right
Extrême Droite	Far-right
Extrême Gauche	Far-left
Front National	Far-right
Génération Ecologie	Left
Majorité Présidentielle	Left
Radicaux de Gauche	Left
Régionalistes	Other
Rassemblement pour la République	Right
Parti Socialiste	Left
Union pour la Démocratie Française	Right
Les Verts	Left

1997 Parliamentary Elections	
Political label	**Political orientation**
Parti Communiste Français	Far-left
Divers	Other
Divers Droite	Right
Divers Gauche	Left
Ecologistes	Left
Extrême Droite	Far-right
Extrême Gauche	Far-left
Front National	Far-right
Mouvement Pour la France	Far-right
Parti Radical Socialiste	Left
Rassemblement pour la République	Right
Socialistes	Left
Union pour la Démocratie Française	Right

2002 Parliamentary Elections	
Political label	**Political orientation**
Communistes	Far-left
Chasse, Pêche, Nature et Traditions	Right
Divers	Other
Démocratie Libérale	Right
Divers Droite	Right
Divers Gauche	Left
Ecologistes	Left
Extrême Droite	Far-right
Extrême Gauche	Far-left
Front National	Far-right
Ligue Communiste Révolutionnaire	Far-left
Lutte Ouvrière	Far-left
Mouvement des Citoyens	Left
Mouvement National Républicain	Far-right
Mouvement pour la France	Right
Pôle Républicain	Left
Radicaux de Gauche	Left
Régionalistes	Other
Rassemblement pour la France	Right
Socialistes	Left
Union pour la Démocratie Française	Liberal
Union pour un Mouvement Populaire	Right
Les Verts	Left

2007 Parliamentary Elections	
Political label	**Political orientation**
Communistes	Far-left
Chasse, Pêche, Nature et Traditions	Right
Divers	Other
Divers Droite	Right
Divers Gauche	Left
Ecologistes	Left
Extrême Droite	Far-right
Extrême Gauche	Far-left
Front National	Far-right
Majorité Présidentielle	Right
Mouvement pour la France	Right
Radicaux de Gauche	Left
Régionalistes	Other
Rassemblement pour la France	Right
Socialistes	Left
Union pour la Démocratie Française - Mouvement Démocrate	Liberal
Union pour un Mouvement Populaire	Right
Les Verts	Left

2012 Parliamentary Elections	
Political label	**Political orientation**
Alliance Centriste	Liberal
Autres	Other
Centre pour la France	Liberal
Communistes	Far-left
Divers Droite	Right
Divers Gauche	Left
Ecologistes	Left
Extrême Droite	Far-right
Extrême Gauche	Far-left
Front de Gauche	Far-left
Front National	Far-right
Nouveau Centre	Liberal
Parti Radical	Right
Radicaux de Gauche	Left
Régionalistes	Other
Socialistes	Left
Union pour un Mouvement Populaire	Right
Europe Ecologie - Les Verts	Left

2017 Parliamentary Elections	
Political label	**Political orientation**
Parti Communiste Français	Far-left
Debout la France	Far-right
Divers	Other
Divers Droite	Right
Divers Gauche	Left
Europe Écologie les Verts	Left
Extrême Droite	Far-right
Extrême Gauche	Far-left
France Insoumise	Far-left
Front National	Far-right
Les Républicains	Right
Modem	Liberal
Radicaux de Gauche	Left
Régionalistes	Other
République en Marche	Liberal
Parti Socialiste	Left
Union des Démocrats et Indépendants	Liberal

2022 Parliamentary Elections	
Political label	**Political orientation**
Divers	Other
Divers Centre	Other
Divers Droite	Right
Divers Gauche	Left
Divers Extrême-droite	Far-right
Divers Extrême-gauche	Far-left
Droite Souveraniste	Far-right
Écologiste	Left
Ensemble	Liberal
Extrême-droite	Far-right
Les Républicains	Right
Nupes	Left
Radicaux de Gauche	Left
Réconquête	Far-right
Régionalistes	Other
Rassemblement National	Far-right
Union des Démocrats et Indépendants	Liberal

2024 Parliamentary Elections	
Political label	**Political orientation**
Divers	Other
Divers Centre	Other
Divers Droite	Right
Divers Gauche	Left
Divers Extrême-droite	Far-right
Divers Extrême-gauche	Far-left
Droite Souveraniste	Far-right
Écologiste	Left
Ensemble	Liberal
Extrême-droite	Far-right
Hôrizons	Right
Les Républicains	Right
Nupes	Left
Radicaux de Gauche	Left
Réconquête	Far-right
Régionalistes	Other
Rassemblement National	Far-right
Union des Démocrats et Indépendants	Liberal
Union de Gauche	Left
Union Extrême-droite	Far-right

B Data

B.1 Political platforms

I transform the pdf versions of the manifestos into text using optical character recognition: Mistral OCR.

I perform the following pre-processing procedures.

I remove words containing party names, party acronyms, parliamentary titles, and terms describing blocs of parties. I also eliminate first and last names.

I pre-process the corpus following standard natural language processing practices: remove punctuation and numbers, convert all letters to lowercase, lemmatize each word, and restrict the vocabulary to words used in at least 1% and 50% of the documents, using the Spacy French version 3.5.0. Because OCR sometimes fails to detect accents, I convert words from Latin-1 to UTF-8 to reduce errors.

Some politicians opt for using the party platform instead of a personalized plat-

form; this is common in small parties (e.g., Rassemblement National and Green parties) but an infrequent practice among well-established parties (e.g., socialist and republican parties). I do not include manifestos similar to the party platform in the training datasets. Keeping duplicate measures introduces multicollinearity, making these manifestos count more. I include them in the regression model.

Table B1: Sampling frame

	First round			Second round		
Year	Races	Total candidates	Platforms collected	Races	Total candidates	Platforms collected
1981	491	2650	2459	334	660	652
1988	577	2849	2651	455	899	852
1993	577	5290	4119	497	992	964
1997	577	6359	2908	565	1197	1097
2002	577	8444	201	519	1045	55
2007	577	7634	395	467	933	80
2012	577	6603	862	541	1101	518
2017	577	7877	5768	573	1146	927
2022	577	6289	4902	561	1126	1059
2024	577	4009	2754	501	1094	850

Notes: The table shows the number of races, total candidates, and manifestos collected for each legislative election in the data set.

Figure B.1: Florence Blatrix-Contat political platform during 1st round 2017 legislative elections - 1st page



51 ans, mariée, 3 enfants

Je vis dans mon village natal à Drom, au cœur du Revermont.

Mes grands-parents agriculteurs et mes parents m'ont transmis leur attachement à ces terres ; ils m'ont surtout appris que l'école était un moyen d'émancipation et d'ascension sociale.

Après des études comptables, je suis devenue enseignante. Agrégée d'économie-gestion, j'enseigne l'économie et le droit.

Elue depuis 1995 dans ma commune, puis en 2015 à la Région Auvergne-Rhône-Alpes, je suis convaincue que l'action publique et la volonté permettent d'avancer.
Dans nos collectivités, je suis attachée à travailler avec tous, au-delà des clivages partisans ; c'est grâce au rassemblement des élus que les projets peuvent aboutir.

Madame, Monsieur,

Le 7 mai dernier, le peuple français a fait le choix d'un nouveau président de la République.

Les élections législatives des 11 et 18 juin** décideront de l'avenir de la France ; elles seront l'occasion de choisir la République que nous voulons. Je me présente à vos suffrages avec la volonté de faire réussir la France, de faire réussir ce quinquennat. La majorité issue de ce scrutin devra agir pour la justice sociale, la solidarité, l'égalité des chances et la transition écologique. **Pour cela, la gauche doit être forte à l'Assemblée nationale.

*Demain, à l'Assemblée, je veux représenter une gauche constructive et exigeante. **Je veillerai à la défense des acquis sociaux, au respect du dialogue social et me battrai pour un modèle de croissance compatible avec la préservation de la planète.***

*Avec mon suppléant, **Michel FONTAINE, nous vivons, travaillons et sommes investis dans cette circonscription**. Nous mettrons notre expérience à votre service pour développer sur ce territoire : l'emploi, les services publics, la santé, la solidarité, mais aussi les activités culturelles et sportives indispensables au lien social. Élue rurale, je sais à quel point les services publics doivent être préservés dans chaque commune.*

Sur le terrain comme à l'Assemblée, je mettrai toute mon énergie pour accompagner et soutenir les projets de notre territoire et pour aider celles et ceux qui rencontrent des difficultés.

Dimanche 11 juin, je compte sur votre soutien. Vous pouvez compter sur ma détermination et mon dévouement.

Florence Blatrix Contat

Source: RegardsCitoyens (https://github.com/regardscitoyens)

Figure B.2: Florence Blatrix-Contat political platform during 1st round 2017 legislative elections - 2nd page



Michel FONTAINE

Premier-adjoint de la Ville de Bourg-en-Bresse
Président de l'Agglomération de 2008 à fin 2016 et depuis Vice-président au développement économique.

Je vis sur Bourg-en-Bresse depuis plus de 40 ans, j'ai partagé ma vie professionnelle entre le lycée Carriat et ma société FontainePicard.

J'ai deux enfants et vis maritalement. J'ai assumé des responsabilités associatives avant de devenir un élu local.

En m'engageant aux côtés de Florence Blatrix-Contat, je fais le choix de la réussite dans une grande fidélité à mes convictions.

NATIONALEMENT, je serai une députée constructive mais exigeante vis-à-vis des réformes proposées par le président de la République, fidèle aux valeurs qui fondent mon engagement politique à Gauche.

Je soutiendrai

→ **La moralisation de la vie publique et l'interdiction du cumul** de plus de trois mandats successifs pour permettre le renouvellement

→ Les projets visant à concilier **efficacité économique et justice sociale** ainsi qu'une action forte en matière de **formation pour lutter contre le chômage**

→ La priorité donnée à l'école primaire pour que chaque enfant puisse réussir et le soutien à l'autonomie des jeunes par une **revalorisation des bourses**

→ Les mesures en faveur du pouvoir d'achat pour les plus modestes avec **l'augmentation du minimum vieillesse et de la prime d'activité**

→ **La transition écologique et énergétique** : des investissements dans la croissance verte et les économies d'énergie, l'interdiction des perturbateurs endocriniens

Je serai vigilante

→ Sur la justice fiscale : **je m'opposerai à la baisse de l'Impôt Sur la Fortune et à l'augmentation de la CSG** qui entraînera une diminution des pensions pour plus de 8 millions de retraités

→ Sur le dialogue social et les droits des salariés : **le dialogue social doit être renforcé** et le Code du travail doit rester un socle protecteur élevé pour les salariés

→ Sur les services publics : « Ils sont le patrimoine de ceux qui n'en ont pas » ; je m'opposerai à une nouvelle baisse du nombre de fonctionnaires et des **dotations des collectivités**

LOCALEMENT, je défendrai les projets de nos territoires : fibre optique, investissement dans l'université, dans les activités sportives et culturelles, lutte contre les déserts médicaux et maintien des services en milieu rural.

« Ce quinquennat sera réussi si la France n'oublie personne en route. Pour cela, nous avons besoin d'une gauche forte. Je sais que Florence et Michel portent ces valeurs. Je vous appelle à les soutenir les 11 et 18 juin prochains. » **Jean-François DEBAT**



Vu le candidat - Agence TOUT&POSSIBLE - Imprimerie du Centre - Bourg-en-Bresse

Candidate de la gauche, des démocrates et des écologistes, je compte sur vous dès le 1er tour.

PS Social-Écologie · Europe écologie les Verts · PRG Parti Radical de Gauche · udé Union des Démocrates et Écologistes

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florenceblatrix · @FlorenceBlatrix

(continuation)

B.2 Measurement

B.2.1 Topics: CamemBERT

Table B2: Prompt shared with ChatGPT to classify a sample of paragraphs into topics

You are an expert in French political science. You must classify political paragraphs into EXACTLY ONE OR TWO categories. Rules: - Indicate the most obvious category. If there are several, also indicate the second most obvious one. Respond with a comma-separated list. - No comments - No additional text - Choose only from the following categories: "Immigration": immigration, migrants, borders, asylum, citizenship. Example: "We need to strengthen border controls to limit illegal immigration." "Justice and Crime": police, justice, crime, defense, terrorism, courts, prisons. Example: "The number of burglaries has increased in suburban areas." "Health": health care, hospitals, medicine, public health, health safety. Example: "Medical deserts are affecting more and more rural counties." "Economy": public finances, taxation, budget, deficit, fiscal policy, public debt, taxes, VAT, public spending, fiscal and monetary policy, businesses, industry, trade, markets, economic growth, exports, entrepreneurship, SMEs. Example: "The budget deficit exceeds 3% of GDP this year." Example: "The reindustrialization of the region is a priority for our SMEs." "Environment": climate, ecology, energy, pollution, agriculture, biodiversity, nuclear power, renewable energy, energy transition. Example: "France must accelerate its transition to renewable energy." "Education": schools, universities, teaching, training, students, scientific research. Example: "The shortage of teachers in rural areas is a cause for concern." "Employment and Social Security": work, unemployment, wages, pensions, labor relations, unions, social protection. Example: "The pension reform plans to raise the legal retirement age to 64." "Foreign Policy": foreign policy, Europe, international relations, diplomacy, international treaties. Example: "France must strengthen its role within European institutions."

"Local politics": sentences relating to local authorities, municipalities, departments, regions, mayors, municipal or regional elections, decentralization, and local powers.
Example: "Mayors are demanding greater administrative autonomy for their municipalities."
"Politics": sentences relating to the functioning of national political institutions, political parties, the results of legislative or presidential elections, relations between the government and the opposition, parliamentary procedures, political alliances, and election polls.
Example: "I ask you to remain mobilized until Sunday for these elections, the most important of the Fifth Republic."
"Other": Does not clearly fall under any of the above categories. In this case, simply indicate that this is the only category.

Table B3: Topics per-class performance

Topic	Precision	Recall	F1-score
Economy	0.86	0.89	0.88
Employment & social security	0.87	0.90	0.88
Environment	0.90	0.90	0.90
Health	0.93	0.83	0.88
Education	0.85	0.86	0.86
Justice & criminality	0.87	0.87	0.87
Immigration	0.85	0.80	0.82
Foreign policy	0.80	0.88	0.84
Local politics	0.87	0.88	0.88
National politics	0.89	0.89	0.89
Other	0.86	0.81	0.83

Notes: Per-class performance comparison between the training and test samples. Scores range from 0 to 1, where 1 indicates perfect agreement.

Table B4: Topics per-class performance: final topics classification vs human annotator

Topic	Precision	Recall	F1-score
Female-stereotyped	0.682	0.824	0.746
Male stereotyped	0.782	0.748	0.764
Other	0.953	0.961	0.957

Notes: Per-class performance comparison between the final topic classification and a human annotator. Scores range from 0 to 1, where 1 indicates perfect agreement. The comparison is made for a random sample of 1000 paragraphs.

Table B5: Topics per-class performance: final topics classification vs LLM classification

Topic	Precision	Recall	F1-score
Female-stereotyped	0.764	0.816	0.789
Male stereotyped	0.836	0.760	0.797
Other	0.988	0.948	0.967

Notes: Per-class performance comparison between the final topic classification and an LLM classifier (ChatGPT 5.4 version). Scores range from 0 to 1, where 1 indicates perfect agreement. The comparison uses a random sample of 1000 paragraphs, the same sample used to evaluate per-class performance between the final topic classification and the human annotator.

Table B6: Topics per-class performance: human annotator vs LLM classification

Topic	Precision	Recall	F1-score
Female-stereotyped	0.718	0.813	0.763
Male stereotyped	0.736	0.774	0.754
Other	0.940	0.988	0.963

Notes: Per-class performance comparison between the human annotator and an LLM classifier (ChatGPT 5.4 version). Scores range from 0 to 1, where 1 indicates perfect agreement. The comparison uses a random sample of 1000 paragraphs, the same sample used to evaluate per-class performance between the final topic classification and the human annotator.

B.2.2 Agentic vs communal language

Table B7: Prompt shared with ChatGPT to classify a sample of paragraphs into agentic language

You are a research assistant in political science. You are given a segment (a phrase, short paragraph, headline, or bullet point) taken from the campaign platform of a candidate in the French legislative elections. Question: In this excerpt, does the candidate present themselves in an AGENTIC register? The agentic register emphasizes the candidate's action, strength, and self-control: determination, tenacity, courage, firmness, energy, independence, and the ability to make decisions, lead, and achieve results. Analyze the MANNER in which the candidate presents themselves, not the TOPIC being addressed. An action verb alone is not enough: it must be the candidate themselves who acts, commits, or claims a result. STEP 1 – Does the segment mention the candidate? Yes, if the subject is: - the candidate in the first person ("I," "me," "my"); - the candidate along with their team, party, or majority ("we");

- the candidate referred to in the third person (by name, “the representative,” “the candidate”), including when their alternate or a supporter is describing them.
No, if the subject is only: the party leader or the President (“elect me Prime Minister,” “Emmanuel Macron needs a majority”); voters, “the French people,” “our people”; a third party discussing their own actions; or no one (impersonal sentence, infinitive, noun phrase).
If no → answer 0.

STEP 2 – Answer 1 if the segment contains at least one of the following EXPLICIT phrases:
a) the candidate’s determination or combativeness: “I will fight,” “I won’t give up,” “relentlessly,” “with determination,” “my fight for…,” “we will defend…”;
b) a firm personal commitment to act on a specific goal: “I will defend our farmers,” “I will achieve,” “I will propose a law,” “I pledge to…,” “I want to take action for…”;
c) an action accomplished or a result achieved by the candidate: “I secured,” “I got it passed,” “he fought to save the police station and was heard”; a nominal achievement counts if it is clearly attributed to the candidate (“12 beds created thanks to my amendment”);
d) character traits attributed to the candidate: determined, competent, experienced, serious, combative, courageous, firm, resolute, dynamic, energetic, effective, independent, “free from any instructions,” “results-oriented”;
e) intense personal effort: “I traveled 6,000 kilometers during the campaign.”

Answer 0 in all other cases, including:
- titles, subheadings, and policy measures expressed in the infinitive or as nouns, even when using strong verbs (“Fighting crime,” “DEFENDING FRANCE,” “Winning the battle to open up isolated areas”);
- campaign pledges in the future tense using “we” (referring to the party or the majority), without any sense of determination or resolve (“We will eliminate the housing tax”);
- descriptions of the role of a member of Congress without concrete action (“I will be your representative,” “I will represent the district,” “I will be your liaison”);

- calls to vote or mobilize, even combative ones (“Together, we can win,” “Mobilize!” “Let’s get France back on track,” “Now is the time to seize our opportunity,” “Nothing is inevitable!”);
- slogans, names of parties or coalitions, headers, dates, contact information, or segments that are illegible or too fragmented;
- profession, age, family status, degrees, or elected offices, without a narrative of accomplishments;
- participation in an activity without claiming any results (“Participation in Senate hearings”);
- opinions or observations (“I believe it’s possible to defeat unemployment,” “The situation calls for action”);
- attacks on opponents that say nothing about the candidate;
- polite phrases, greetings, thanks, or requests for support;
- interpersonal qualities (being a good listener, approachability, sincerity, humility): these belong to a different category.
Exception : un slogan ou un titre qui attribue explicitement une qualité agentique au candidat compte (« Une députée déterminée pour la Corrèze » → 1).

Examples:
“I will fight tirelessly to keep the maternity ward open” → 1
“As an incumbent representative, I secured the reopening of the rail line” → 1
“If elected, I will defend our farmers in the National Assembly” → 1
“You can count on my determination” → 1
“I WILL PROTECT THE FRENCH PEOPLE!” → 1
“Marie, a hands-on, determined, and effective woman” → 1
“Protecting the French people” → 0 (title in the infinitive)
“The maternity ward must remain open” → 0 (policy statement)
“We will lower taxes and create 10,000 daycare spots” → 0 (policy measures)
“On Sunday, we can win. Get out and vote!” → 0 (call to vote)
“I will be your representative, serving everyone” → 0 (role, not action)
“I will listen to concerned families” → 0 (relational register)
“Engineer, county council member, 45 years old” → 0
“Thank you for putting me in the lead in the first round” → 0
“Elect me Prime Minister: my government will freeze prices” → 0 (the “I” refers to the party leader)

Additional rules:

- If the segment contains multiple sentences, answer 1 as soon as any part meets the conditions.
- Do not infer anything that is not written: if there is no explicit indication, answer 0.
- Do not take grammatical gender into account ("determiné" = "déterminée").
- The text may contain OCR errors: code it as best you can, without correcting them.

Format: Answer only with the number 1 or the number 0, without any other characters.

Table B8: Prompt shared with ChatGPT to classify a sample of paragraphs into agentic language

You are a research assistant in political science. You are given a segment (a phrase, short paragraph, title, or bullet point) taken from the campaign platform of a candidate in the French legislative elections.
Question: In this segment, does the candidate present himself or herself in a RELATIONAL register, focused on others?
The relational register emphasizes the candidate's connection with others and their concern for others: listening, approachability, availability, being present among residents, attention to people, empathy, kindness, humility, sincerity, and honesty; a spirit of dialogue, consultation, and cooperation; and a willingness to act with residents rather than for them.
Focus on the MANNER in which the candidate presents themselves, not the TOPIC being addressed. A social issue or a warm word is not enough: it must be the candidate themselves who demonstrates this connection or this concern.

STEP 1 – Does the segment mention the candidate?
Yes, if the subject is:
- the candidate in the first person ("I," "me," "my");
- the candidate along with their team, party, or majority ("we");
- the candidate referred to in the third person (by name, "the representative," "the candidate"), including when their alternate or a supporter is describing them.
No, if the subject is only: the party leader or the President; voters, "the French people," "our people"; a third party speaking about themselves; or no one (impersonal phrase, infinitive, noun phrase).

If no → answer 0.

STEP 2 – Answer 1 if the segment contains at least one of the following EXPLICIT keywords:
a) the candidate's willingness to listen, attention, or empathy toward voters, residents, or members of civil society (organizations, businesses, local elected officials with whom the candidate works in the area): "I'm here to listen to you," "I understand and share your concerns," "I will ensure the well-being of our seniors";
b) approachability, availability, and presence: "close to you," "always by your side," "available," "you can count on me," "a woman who works on the ground," office hours, an explicit invitation to come meet the candidate, accounts of meetings with residents;
c) dialogue, consultation, or cooperation with residents or local stakeholders: "a man of dialogue," "a unifier," "I will bring elected officials and organizations together to build solutions together," "I will build this project with you";
d) role as a liaison for people: "I will be your spokesperson, so that your concerns are heard," "the elected official who makes your voice heard";
e) moral or interpersonal qualities attributed to the candidate: modest, sincere, honest, generous, tolerant, warm, kind, "a man of his word," acknowledgment of his own limitations;
f) shared experiences with residents: "Like you, I understand the difficulties of our daily lives."

Answer 0 in all other cases, including:
- focus on policies, institutions, or facilities rather than people ("I will focus on the effectiveness of our policies," "… on the development of the air base");
- a call for someone other than the candidate to pay attention ("We will ask the government to remain attentive to the elderly");
- social or solidarity policies described as measures ("Increase the disability allowance for adults");
- descriptions of voters' feelings without the candidate taking a stance ("Many of you are concerned");
- polite phrases, greetings, signatures ("Dear Madam, Dear Sir," "Respectfully"), thanks to voters ("thank you for your trust"), requests for support or votes ("I ask for your trust," "I know I can count on you");

- contact information only (address, phone number, email, website, social media);
- a connection to or attachment to the local area that has no relation to the residents (“born in this city,” “deeply rooted in our district”);
- rallying around a party, a majority, or the President, or relationships with national leaders (“unite all our efforts to support the majority,” “we must come together,” “we are friends with future ministers”);
- profession, degrees, or elected offices, even in the social sector (“president of an association managing a nursing home”);
- determination or combativeness (agentive register);
- slogans and nominal titles, names of parties or coalitions (“Together”), attacks, calls to vote, illegible or overly fragmented segments.
Exception: a slogan or title that explicitly attributes a relational quality to the candidate counts (“A representative always by your side” $\rightarrow$ 1).

Examples:
“I will listen to families who are concerned about the future of the maternity ward” $\rightarrow$ 1
“I’ll be available and close to you—I’ll hold weekly office hours” $\rightarrow$ 1
“Paul, a man of dialogue, always by your side” $\rightarrow$ 1
“During the campaign, I went out to meet you at markets and community organizations” $\rightarrow$ 1
“I understand your difficulties and share them” $\rightarrow$ 1
“I have my flaws, but I promise to be a sincere representative” $\rightarrow$ 1
“You can count on me” $\rightarrow$ 1
“I know I can count on you” $\rightarrow$ 0 (request for support)
“Thank you for your trust in the first round” $\rightarrow$ 0 (expression of gratitude)
“Ladies and gentlemen, fellow citizens,” $\rightarrow$ 0
“To reach me: 01 23 45 67 89” $\rightarrow$ 0
“CLOSENESS, TRANSPARENCY, RENEWAL” $\rightarrow$ 0 (nominal slogan)
“I will pay close attention to the development of the industrial zone” $\rightarrow$ 0 (focus on infrastructure)
“Increase the disability allowance for adults” $\rightarrow$ 0
“We will ask the government to remain attentive to the issues facing the elderly” $\rightarrow$ 0
“I will fight tirelessly for maternity care” $\rightarrow$ 0 (agentive register)

"Respected by his colleagues across the political spectrum in the National Assembly, he will be able to secure funding for our department" → 0 (esteem from his peers, used to leverage his influence)

Additional rules:
- If the segment contains multiple sentences, answer 1 as soon as any part meets the conditions.
- Do not infer anything that is not written: if there is no explicit indication, answer 0.
- Do not take grammatical gender into account ("attentif" = "attentive").
- The text may contain OCR errors: code it as best you can, without correcting them.

Format: Answer only with the number 1 or the number 0, without any other characters.

Table B9: Communication style per-class performance: human annotator vs LLM classification

Topic	Precision	Recall	F1-score
Agentic	0.919	0.911	0.915
Communal	0.886	0.873	0.879

Notes: Per-class performance comparison between the human annotator and an LLM classifier (ChatGPT 5.4 version). Scores range from 0 to 1, where 1 indicates perfect agreement. The comparison uses a random sample of 1000 paragraphs.

C Empirical strategy

Table C10: Summary statistics

	First-round				Second-round				Adjustment			
	Women		Men		Women		Men		Women		Men	
	All	Near	All	Near	All	Near	All	Near	All	Near	All	Near
Female-stereotyped	0.114	0.128	0.094	0.103	0.103	0.102	0.072	0.084	-0.025	-0.021	-0.026	-0.018
	(0.101)	(0.090)	(0.091)	(0.090)	(0.087)	(0.092)	(0.083)	(0.091)	(0.077)	(0.063)	(0.083)	(0.078)
Male-stereotyped	0.115	0.126	0.104	0.137	0.107	0.124	0.091	0.121	-0.016	-0.008	-0.010	-0.016
	(0.136)	(0.166)	(0.132)	(0.181)	(0.138)	(0.166)	(0.127)	(0.170)	(0.085)	(0.093)	(0.087)	(0.097)
Other	0.884	0.884	0.899	0.894	0.896	0.891	0.921	0.903	0.013	0.007	0.018	0.009
	(0.100)	(0.103)	(0.103)	(0.096)	(0.105)	(0.114)	(0.101)	(0.108)	(0.081)	(0.088)	(0.086)	(0.092)
Health	0.056	0.059	0.040	0.052	0.052	0.053	0.031	0.047	-0.011	-0.007	-0.008	-0.007
	(0.057)	(0.055)	(0.055)	(0.061)	(0.056)	(0.057)	(0.050)	(0.062)	(0.046)	(0.041)	(0.046)	(0.051)
Education	0.065	0.078	0.059	0.058	0.056	0.055	0.043	0.040	-0.015	-0.017	-0.019	-0.016
	(0.085)	(0.069)	(0.074)	(0.066)	(0.062)	(0.061)	(0.062)	(0.056)	(0.063)	(0.055)	(0.068)	(0.053)
Justice	0.077	0.087	0.069	0.088	0.085	0.087	0.069	0.078	-0.004	-0.000	-0.004	-0.008
	(0.080)	(0.084)	(0.083)	(0.089)	(0.103)	(0.104)	(0.095)	(0.097)	(0.067)	(0.075)	(0.074)	(0.067)
Immigration	0.056	0.059	0.049	0.070	0.045	0.051	0.038	0.058	-0.011	-0.013	-0.006	-0.013
	(0.122)	(0.155)	(0.108)	(0.168)	(0.110)	(0.130)	(0.094)	(0.140)	(0.111)	(0.123)	(0.084)	(0.135)
Observations	7909	175	19094	200	1674	162	5376	187	1598	150	5151	167

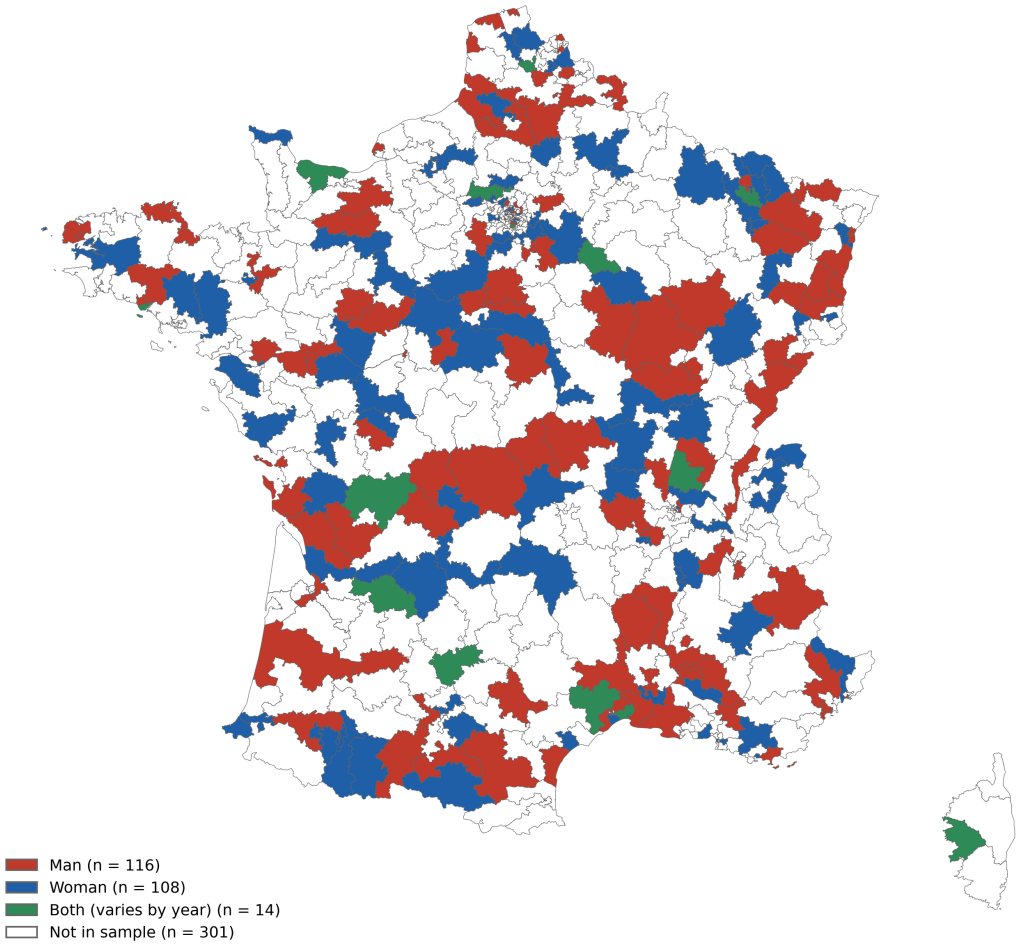
'All' refers to all candidates. 'Near' refers to the candidates where the running variable is within 3 p.p. of the cut-off. Standard errors are in parenthesis.

Table C11: Regression discontinuity design sampling frame

Year	Districts	Candidates	Mean margin
1981	1	1	7.474
1988	3	3	7.138
1993	138	138	6.299
1997	24	24	4.814
2002	2	2	3.880
2007	2	2	7.777
2012	11	11	4.758
2017	298	298	3.795
2022	308	308	4.672
2024	11	11	3.319

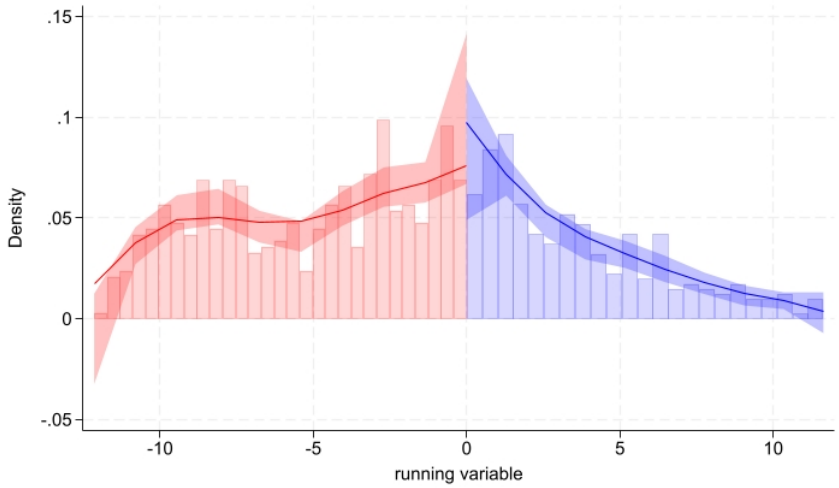
Notes: Column 'Districts' indicates the number of electoral districts included in the regression discontinuity design for the respective year, 'Candidates' refers to the number of candidates included, and 'Mean margin' is the average running variable.

Figure C.3: Geographic variation within 3 percentage points of the cutoff



C.1 Internal validity

Figure C.4: Manipulation testing: Most voted female - most voted male



Notes. The figure shows the density test for races where only one candidate (or none) received 12.5%; the margin is the difference between the most-voted woman and the most-voted man (ignoring the opponent in the second round). The figure illustrates the Cattaneo et al. (2018) manipulation test; p-value 0.600 (do not reject the null hypothesis of no manipulation).

I conduct placebo tests to examine whether there is discontinuity at the threshold for each variable used to predict treatment. I provide information about the construction of each variable. If the information is missing, it is because the name of the dependent variable is self-explanatory.

Turnout: share of enrolled voters that voted. Continuous variable from 0 to 100.

Number candidates: number of candidates running in the electoral district.

Number female candidates: number of female candidates running in the electoral district.

Elected a woman in the past: dummy variable equal to 1 if the district elected a woman in a previous election, 0 otherwise.

Wage gap: Le Barbanchon and Sauvagnat (2022) gender bias estimation; they computed the residualized local earnings gaps after controlling for age, industry, and occupation. The data miss observations for some electoral districts outside of metropolitan France.

Number far-left, left, liberal, right, far-right, other: Number of candidates of the respective ideology.

Sum of far-left, left, liberal, right, far-right, other: sum of the vote share in all candidates of the respective ideology.

Votes: number of votes obtained divided by the number of enrolled voters.

Victory margin: difference between the share of votes obtained in the first round by the candidate and the opponent in the second round.

Run in the past: dummy equal to 1 if the candidate has run for legislative elections in the past, 0 if not.

Out of labor force: dummy equal to 1 if the candidate does not participate in the labor market (e.g., unemployed, retired, student).

High skilled: dummy equal to 1 if the candidate is a high skilled worker (e.g., manager, doctor, university professor, lawyer, journalist), 0 otherwise.

Middle skilled: dummy equal to 1 if it is a middle skilled worker (e.g., technician, travel agent, militar, kindergarten teacher, foreman), 0 otherwise.

Low skilled: dummy equal to 1 if it is a low skilled worker (e.g., minor, craftsman, driver, industrial worker), 0 otherwise.

Far-left, left, liberal, right, far-right: a dummy equal to 1 if the politician is classified as belonging to that ideology, 0 if not.

Run: dummy equal to 1 if the candidate was eligible for the 2nd round and decided to run, 0 if he was eligible but decided not to run.

Available: dummy equal to 1 if the manifesto for the 1st and 2nd round is available, 0 if not.

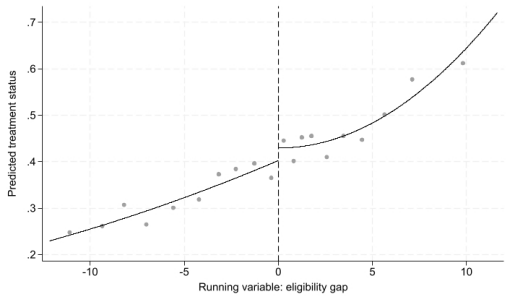
Table C12: Balancing tests: 1st round electoral district characteristics

	(1) Turnout	(2) Number candidates	(3) Number female candidates	(4) Enrolled voters	(5) Elected a woman in the past	(6) Wage gap
Woman	-0.620	0.293	0.319	-7,622	0.0538	0.00315
	(6.974)	(0.874)	(0.586)	(4,455)	(0.128)	(0.007)
Observations	798	798	798	798	798	754
Eff. number of obs	294	287	300	291	262	304
Robust p-value	0.879	0.518	0.437	0.0529	0.574	0.617
Polyn. order	1	1	1	1	1	1
Bandwidth	2.815	2.686	2.869	2.766	2.383	3.085
Mean, left of threshold	21.152	11.879	4.733	81989	0.166	0.0709

	(7) Number of far-left	(8) Number of left	(9) Number of liberal	(10) Number of right	(11) Number of far-right	(12) Number of other
Woman	-0.150	-0.074	0.002	0.0671	-0.0351	0.0503
	(0.249)	(0.265)	(0.119)	(0.276)	(0.246)	(0.560)
Observations	798	798	798	798	798	798
Eff. number of obs	407	386	286	400	344	367
Robust p-value	0.624	0.875	0.983	0.706	0.840	0.742
Polyn. order	1	1	1	1	1	1
Bandwidth	4.023	3.852	2.676	3.955	3.241	3.547
Mean, left of threshold	2.137	1.852	0.798	1.840	2.134	3.425

	(13) Sum of far-left	(14) Sum of left	(15) Sum of liberal	(16) Sum of right	(17) Sum of far-right	(18) Sum of other
Woman	0.055	0.870	0.226	-1.249	-1.037	0.490
	(1.126)	(1.938)	(2.129)	(2.754)	(1.399)	(0.795)
Observations	798	798	798	798	798	798
Eff. number of obs	345	326	284	253	283	356
Robust p-value	0.944	0.630	0.766	0.434	0.338	0.423
Polyn. order	1	1	1	1	1	1
Bandwidth	3.281	3.082	2.663	2.245	2.658	3.401
Mean, left of threshold	4.362	10.728	10.021	10.73	10.35	3.207

Figure C.5: General balance test



Notes. Dots represent the local averages of the predicted treatment status (vertical axis). Averages are calculated within quantile bins of the running variable (horizontal axis). The outcome is the candidate's predicted treatment status based on observable characteristics listed in the text. The treatment variable is a dummy equal to 1 if the candidate is a female and qualifies for the second round. The sample is restricted to candidates included in the RDD sample as described in the text. The running variable is the difference between the most-voted woman and the most-voted man (excluding the opponent in the runoff).

Table C13: General balance test

	(1)
Woman	0.049
	(0.050)
Observations	798
Eff. number of obs	300
Robust p-value	0.251
Polyn. order	1
Bandwidth	2.869
Mean, left of threshold	0.385

The outcome is the candidate's predicted treatment status based on observable characteristics listed in the text. The outcome is computed as follows: for column (1), first, the treatment variable T is regressed on all 18 baseline variables presented in Table C12, and then the treatment status of each candidate is predicted using the regression coefficients. The sample is restricted to candidates included in the RDD sample as described in the text. The independent variable is an indicator equal to 1 if the candidate is a female. I use a nonparametric estimation procedure and MSERD data-driven bandwidths. Standard errors are in parentheses and clustered at the district-year level. The mean gives the average outcome value for the male candidates at the threshold.

Table C14: Balancing tests: individual characteristics

	(1) Votes	(2) Victory margin	(3) Incumbent	(4) Run in the past
Woman	0.256	0.616	-0.000	-0.0388
	(0.603)	(1.733)	(0.118)	(0.137)
Observations	798	798	798	798
Eff. number of obs	312	292	286	302
Robust p-value	0.766	0.597	0.967	0.723
Polyn. order	1	1	1	1
Bandwidth	2.981	2.780	2.682	2.882
Mean, left of threshold	8.885	-7.705	0.173	0.323

	(5)	(6)	(7)	(8)	(9)
			Occupation		
	Out of labor force	High skilled	Middle skilled	Low skilled	Missing
Woman	0.022	-0.034	-0.037	0.0602	0.0913
	(0.078)	(0.116)	(0.109)	(0.0594)	(0.0751)
Observations	798	798	798	798	798
Eff. number of obs	382	409	288	217	255
Robust p-value	0.698	0.756	0.616	0.157	0.140
Polyn. order	1	1	1	1	1
Bandwidth	3.797	4.050	2.696	1.894	2.297
Mean, left of threshold	0.099	0.673	0.169	-0.0146	0.0101

	(10)	(11)	(12)	(13)	(14)
			Age group		
	<25	25-44	45-64	>= 65	Missing
Woman	0.014	-0.016	0.082	-0.110	0.0260
	(0.030)	(0.157)	(0.164)	(0.0841)	(0.0462)
Observations	798	798	798	798	798
Eff. number of obs	409	260	257	317	312
Robust p-value	0.559	0.755	0.460	0.174	0.530
Polyn. order	1	1	1	1	1
Bandwidth	4.063	2.331	2.312	3.001	2.957
Mean, left of threshold	0.018	0.342	0.489	0.128	0.0251

	(15)	(16)	(17)	(18)	(19)	(20)
			Political ideology			
	Far-left	Left	Liberal	Right	Far-right	Other
Woman	0.034	0.129	0.026	-0.173	0.0356	-0.0209
	(0.090)	(0.137)	(0.106)	(0.089)	(0.091)	(0.040)
Observations	798	798	798	798	798	798
Eff. number of obs	339	312	384	377	333	387
Robust p-value	0.855	0.288	0.970	0.0708	0.544	0.604
Polyn. order	1	1	1	1	1	1
Bandwidth	3.208	2.978	3.818	3.734	3.116	3.867
Mean, left of threshold	0.104	0.296	0.209	0.206	0.128	0.0388

Standard errors are in parentheses and clustered at the district-year level. The unit of observation is the candidate. The independent variable is a dummy equal to 1 if the candidate is a woman. Each column reports the results from a separate local polynomial regression. Separate polynomials are fitted on each side of the threshold. The polynomial order is 1, and the optimal bandwidths are derived under the MSERD procedure.

Table C15: Balancing tests - differences in the ideology of female and male opponents

	(1) Far-left	(2) Left	(3) Liberal	(4) Right	(5) Far-right	(6) Other
Woman	0.020	-0.096	0.081	0.109	-0.072	0.012
	(0.025)	(0.102)	(0.158)	(0.135)	(0.101)	(0.021)
Observations	798	798	798	798	798	798
Eff. number of obs	346	361	263	266	357	292
Robust p-value	0.386	0.336	0.466	0.506	0.367	0.465
Polyn. order	1	1	1	1	1	1
Bandwidth	3.289	3.465	2.422	2.479	3.416	2.779
Mean, left of threshold	0.000	0.214	0.306	0.195	0.237	0.002

Standard errors are in parentheses and clustered at the district-year level. The unit of observation is the candidate. The independent variable is a dummy equal to 1 if the candidate is a woman. Each column reports the results from a separate local polynomial regression. Separate polynomials are fitted on each side of the threshold. The polynomial order is 1, and the optimal bandwidths are derived under the MSERD procedure.

Table C16: Differences in topic adjustment between right-wing and non-right-wing candidates

	(1) Female-stereotyped	(2) Male-stereotyped	(3) Other	(4) Agentic	(5) Communal
Woman	0.002	0.008	0.077	-0.018	-0.026
	(0.033)	(0.036)	(0.046)	(0.042)	(0.028)
Observations	436	436	436	436	436
Eff. number of obs	146	142	143	151	117
Robust p-value	0.762	0.876	0.062	0.611	0.282
Polyn. order	1	1	1	1	1
Bandwidth	2.387	2.330	2.351	2.541	1.892
Mean, left of threshold	-0.013	-0.017	-0.043	-0.002	-0.006

Standard errors in parentheses are clustered at the district-year level. Each column reports the results from a separate local polynomial regression. The analysis is restricted to males. The variable of interest is a being right-wing rather than another ideology (far-left, left, liberal, far-right or other). Separate polynomials are fitted on each side of the threshold. The polynomial order is 1, and the optimal bandwidths are derived under the MSERD procedure. The dependent variables take values between 0 and 1, and their computation is similar to the one in Section 3.3. The mean gives the average outcome value for non-right-wing candidates at the threshold.

Table C17: Differences in sample selection between female and male candidates

	(1) 2nd round happends	(2) Platform available
Woman	-0.000	-0.064
	(0.023)	(0.111)
Observations	1304	1304
Eff. number of obs	593	512
Robust p-value	0.858	0.508
Polyn. order	1	1
Bandwidth	3.453	2.943
Mean, left of threshold	0.988	0.617

Column (1) is a dummy variable equal to 1 if there is a 2nd round. Column (2) is a dummy variable equal to 1 if the political platform is available for both rounds. The unit of observation is the candidate. The independent variable is a dummy equal to 1 if it is a female candidate. Each column reports the results from a separate local polynomial regression. Separate polynomials are fitted on each side of the threshold. The polynomial order is 1, and the optimal bandwidths are derived under the MSERD procedure. Standard errors are clustered at the district-year level.

D Results

D.1 Topics

Table D18: Differences in topic adjustment between female and male candidates, by political ideology

	Female-stereotyped		Male-stereotyped		Other	
Ideology	Left	Right	Left	Right	Left	Right
Woman	-0.009	-0.039*	0.015	0.071*	-0.002	-0.092**
	(0.040)	(0.035)	(0.022)	(0.064)	(0.042)	(0.065)
P-value (left)=(right)	0.333		0.142		0.124	
Robust p-value	0.864	0.097	0.518	0.076	0.671	0.036
Observations	312	486	312	486	312	486
Eff. number of obs.	137	197	126	153	134	140
Polyn. order	1	1	1	1	1	1
Bandwidth	3.172	3.151	2.882	2.505	3.032	2.186
Mean, left of threshold	-0.011	-0.012	-0.014	-0.056	0.007	0.091

Notes: Standard errors in parentheses are clustered at the district-year level. Each column reports the results from a separate local polynomial regression. The variable of interest is being a woman rather than a man. Separate polynomials are fitted on each side of the threshold. The polynomial order is 1, and the optimal bandwidths are derived under the MSERD procedure. Coefficients are conventional local polynomial estimates; standard errors, confidence intervals, and p-values are robust bias-corrected following Calonico et al. (2014). The dependent variables take values between 0 and 1, and their computation is explained in Section 3.3. The mean gives the average outcome value for male candidates at the threshold.

Table D19: Differences between female and male 2nd round political candidates (controlling for ideology)

Panel A: Aggregated topic groups

	(1) Female-stereotyped	(2) Male-stereotyped	(3) Other
Woman	-0.023	0.053	-0.063
	(0.017)	(0.024)	(0.029)
Robust p-value	0.163	0.035	0.023
Observations	798	798	798
Eff. number of obs	326	258	232
Polyn. order	1	1	1
Bandwidth	3.072	2.320	2.044
Mean, left of threshold	-0.037	-0.038	0.090

Panel B: Individual topics

	(1) Health	(2) Education	(3) Justice	(4) Immigration	(5) Local	(6) National	(7) Other policy
Woman	-0.025	0.002	0.017	0.054	0.015	-0.063	0.026
	(0.012)	(0.011)	(0.015)	(0.033)	(0.020)	(0.053)	(0.047)
Robust p-value	0.034	0.810	0.405	0.079	0.599	0.202	0.484
Observations	798	798	798	798	798	798	798
Eff. number of obs	262	394	320	253	358	309	354
Polyn. order	1	1	1	1	1	1	1
Bandwidth	2.399	3.922	3.032	2.250	3.426	2.936	3.353
Mean, left of threshold	-0.009	-0.032	-0.015	-0.038	0.007	0.114	-0.080

Notes: Each column reports the results from a separate local polynomial regression. Panel A aggregates the topics into female-stereotyped (health and education), male-stereotyped (justice and criminality, immigration, foreign policy) and remaining topics. Panel B reports the individual topics: health and education compose the female-stereotyped group; justice and criminality, immigration and foreign policy the male-stereotyped group; and local politics, national politics and other policy (economy, employment and social security, and environment) the remaining topics. The variable of interest is being a woman rather than a man. Separate polynomials are fitted on each side of the threshold. The polynomial order is 1, and the optimal bandwidths are derived under the MSERD procedure. Conventional standard errors, clustered at the district-year level, are in parentheses; p-values are robust bias-corrected following Calonico et al. (2014). The dependent variables take values between 0 and 1, and their computation is explained in Section **??**. The mean gives the average outcome value for male candidates at the threshold. All regressions include controls for far-left, left, right, far-right, and other.

Table D20: Differences between female and male 2nd round political candidates (controlling for enrolled voters)

Panel A: Aggregated topic groups

	(1) Female-stereotyped	(2) Male-stereotyped	(3) Other
Woman	-0.020	0.051	-0.062
	(0.016)	(0.024)	(0.029)
Robust p-value	0.231	0.040	0.025
Observations	798	798	798
Eff. number of obs	353	264	231
Polyn. order	1	1	1
Bandwidth	3.342	2.441	2.029
Mean, left of threshold	-0.046	-0.070	0.065

Panel B: Individual topics

	(1) Health	(2) Education	(3) Justice	(4) Immigration	(5) Local	(6) National	(7) Other policy
Woman	-0.025	0.006	0.017	0.053	0.016	-0.071	0.039
	(0.012)	(0.013)	(0.015)	(0.033)	(0.019)	(0.052)	(0.050)
Robust p-value	0.035	0.568	0.362	0.089	0.593	0.151	0.344
Observations	798	798	798	798	798	798	798
Eff. number of obs	266	352	311	262	373	309	333
Polyn. order	1	1	1	1	1	1	1
Bandwidth	2.479	3.328	2.947	2.392	3.644	2.918	3.143
Mean, left of threshold	-0.007	-0.054	-0.023	-0.079	-0.007	0.213	-0.130

Notes: Each column reports the results from a separate local polynomial regression. Panel A aggregates the topics into female-stereotyped (health and education), male-stereotyped (justice and criminality, and immigration) and remaining topics. Panel B reports the individual topics: health and education compose the female-stereotyped group; justice and criminality, and immigration the male-stereotyped group; and local politics, national politics and other policy (economy, employment and social security, environment, and foreign policy) the remaining topics. The variable of interest is being a woman rather than a man. Separate polynomials are fitted on each side of the threshold. The polynomial order is 1, and the optimal bandwidths are derived under the MSERD procedure. Coefficients are conventional local polynomial estimates. Conventional standard errors, clustered at the district-year level, are in parentheses; p-values are robust bias-corrected following Calonico et al. (2014). The dependent variables take values between 0 and 1, and their computation is explained in Section 3.3.1. The mean gives the average outcome value for male candidates at the threshold.

Table D21: Differences between female and male 2nd round political candidates (covariate-adjusted form)

Panel A: Aggregated topic groups

	(1) Female-stereotyped	(2) Male-stereotyped	(3) Other
Woman	-0.018	0.042	-0.045
	(0.015)	(0.020)	(0.023)
Robust p-value	0.215	0.060	0.044
Observations	798	798	798
Eff. number of obs	288	278	244
Polyn. order	1	1	1
Bandwidth	2.720	2.605	2.182
Mean, left of threshold	-0.042	0.089	-0.014

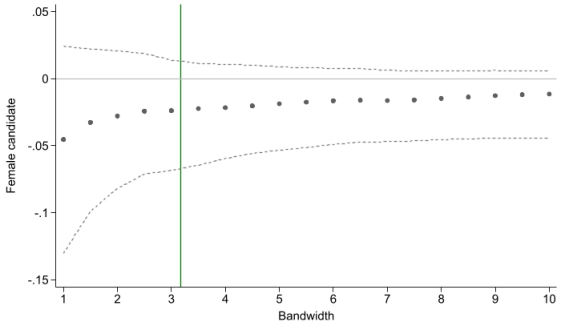
Panel B: Individual topics

	(1) Health	(2) Education	(3) Justice	(4) Immigration	(5) Local	(6) National	(7) Other policy
Woman	-0.022	0.010	0.021	0.035	0.007	-0.079	0.061
	(0.011)	(0.013)	(0.013)	(0.026)	(0.018)	(0.044)	(0.051)
Robust p-value	0.027	0.437	0.209	0.158	0.888	0.066	0.215
Observations	798	798	798	798	798	798	798
Eff. number of obs	267	280	308	266	361	262	262
Polyn. order	1	1	1	1	1	1	1
Bandwidth	2.495	2.629	2.907	2.484	3.475	2.396	2.375
Mean, left of threshold	-0.014	-0.030	-0.086	0.209	0.137	-0.344	-0.096

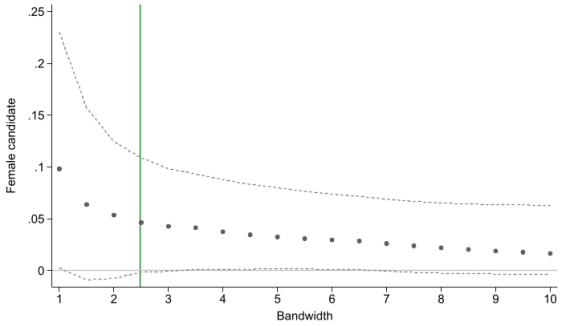
Notes: Each column reports the results from a separate local polynomial regression. Panel A aggregates the topics into female-stereotyped, male-stereotyped, and remaining topics. Panel B reports the individual topics: health and education compose the female-stereotyped group; justice and criminality, and immigration the male-stereotyped group; and local politics, national politics and other policy (economy, employment and social security, environment, and foreign policy) the remaining topics. The variable of interest is being a woman rather than a man. Separate polynomials are fitted on each side of the threshold. The polynomial order is 1, and the optimal bandwidths are derived under the MSERD procedure. Coefficients are conventional local polynomial estimates. Conventional standard errors, clustered at the district-year level, are in parentheses; p-values are robust bias-corrected following Calonico et al. (2014). The dependent variables take values between 0 and 1, and their computation is explained in Section 3.3.1. The mean gives the average outcome value for male candidates at the threshold. All regressions include the covariates listed in Tables C12 and C14.

Figure D.6: Gender differences in topics adjustment between 1st and 2nd round - Robustness to bandwidth choice

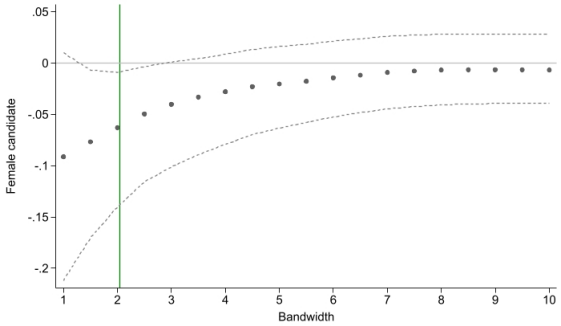
(a) Female-stereotyped



(b) Male-stereotyped



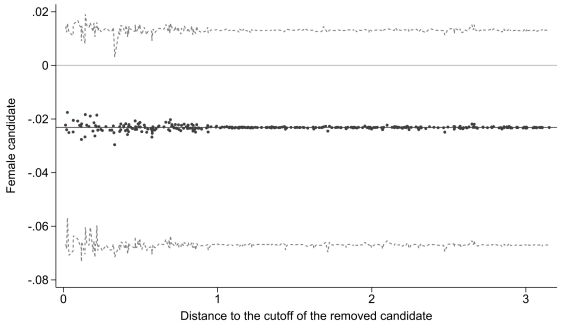
(c) Other



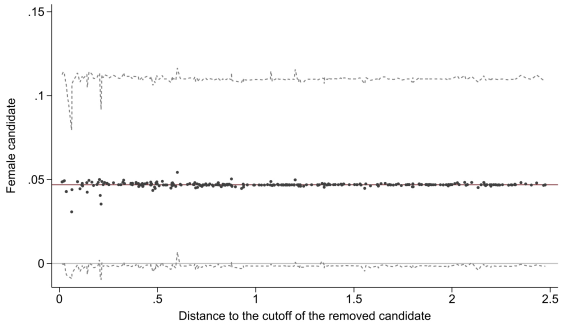
Notes. These figures show the sensitivity of the point estimate to bandwidth choice. Dots represent the estimated treatment effect using different bandwidths (horizontal axis). Dotted lines represent the 95-percent robust confidence interval. The estimates are reported for values of the bandwidth from 1 to 10 percentage points, in steps of 0.5 percentage points. The vertical green line gives the value of the MSERD optimal bandwidth used in the main estimation. The outcome is the change in the respective topic coverage between the first and the second round. The independent variable is an indicator equal to 1 if the female candidate reached the second round, 0 if it is a male.

Figure D.7: Gender differences in topics adjustment between 1st and 2nd round - Leave one candidate out

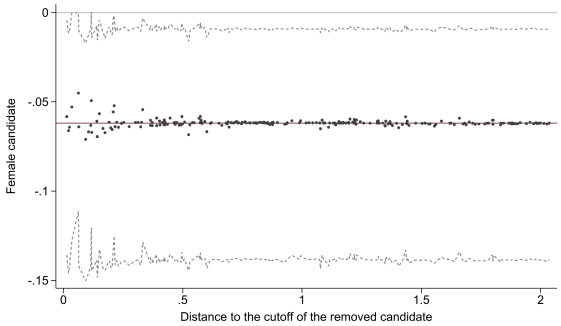
(a) Female-stereotyped



(b) Male-stereotyped



(c) Other



Notes. These figures show the sensitivity of the point estimate when removing one candidate at time. The very first dot on each graph provides the baseline estimate. Then, each dot provides the point estimate associated with removing a given candidate. Candidates are ordered based on the absolute value of their running variable, so that the second dot provides the point estimate associated with removing the candidate the closest to the cutoff. Dotted lines represent the 95-percent robust confidence interval. The outcome is the change in the respective topic coverage between the first and the second round. The independent variable is an indicator equal to 1 if the female candidate reached the second-round, 0 if it is a male.

D.2 Campaigning style: Agentive vs communal

Table D22: Differences in the adjustment of rhetorical register between female and male candidates, by political ideology

	Agentic		Communal	
Ideology	Left	Right	Left	Right
Woman	0.012	0.001	0.045**	0.047***
	(0.039)	(0.035)	(0.036)	(0.022)
P-value (left)=(right)	0.320		0.439	
Robust p-value	0.234	0.871	0.011	0.007
Observations	312	486	312	486
Eff. number of obs.	149	183	127	197
Polyn. order	1	1	1	1
Bandwidth	3.843	2.978	2.892	3.176
Mean, left of threshold	-0.017	0.008	-0.019	-0.013

Notes: The outcome is the change between the first- and second-round platforms in the share of segments written in an agentic or in a communal register; their construction is explained in Section 3.3.2. The sample is split by the political ideology of the candidate who qualified for the second round, with *Right* grouping liberal, right-wing and far-right candidates. The table reports heterogeneous RD estimates of the effect of a woman rather than a man barely qualifying for the second round, estimated with `rdhte` (Calonico et al., 2025): local linear regressions with a triangular kernel and an MSE-optimal bandwidth selected separately for each subgroup. Standard errors clustered by district-year (CR2) in parentheses; stars and robust p-values refer to robust bias-corrected inference. The difference p-value tests whether the RD effect differs between left-wing and right-wing candidates. The mean gives the average outcome value for male candidates at the threshold. Because ideology is a characteristic of the qualifying candidate rather than of the district, and is not perfectly balanced at the threshold, these estimates should be read as descriptive. * $p < 0.10$, ** $> p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Table D23: Differences between how female and male candidates adjust their campaigns between the 1st and 2nd round in terms of agentic vs communal language (controlling for ideology)

Panel A: Agentic language

	(1) Overall	(2) Female-stereotyped	(3) Male-stereotyped	(4) Other
Woman	0.009	0.004	0.001	0.010
	(0.017)	(0.028)	(0.034)	(0.017)
Robust p-value	0.568	0.873	0.830	0.464
Observations	798	798	798	798
Eff. number of obs	319	271	264	263
Polyn. order	1	1	1	1
Bandwidth	3.007	2.541	2.433	2.430
Mean, left of threshold	-0.011	-0.002	-0.001	-0.003

Panel B: Communal language

	(1) Overall	(2) Female-stereotyped	(3) Male-stereotyped	(4) Other
Woman	0.046	0.007	0.037	0.025
	(0.014)	(0.015)	(0.015)	(0.011)
Robust p-value	0.002	0.535	0.019	0.035
Observations	798	798	798	798
Eff. number of obs	288	326	221	362
Polyn. order	1	1	1	1
Bandwidth	2.697	3.084	1.943	3.481
Mean, left of threshold	-0.017	-0.008	-0.016	-0.010

Notes: The outcome is the change between the first- and second-round platforms in the share of segments written in an agentic register (Panel A) or in a communal register (Panel B); their construction is explained in Section **??**. Column (1) uses all segments of the platform; columns (2) to (4) restrict attention to the segments classified in each topic group, so that the measure is the register used *within* that content and is not mechanically affected by changes in topic salience. Each column reports the results from a separate local polynomial regression. The variable of interest is being a woman rather than a man. Separate polynomials are fitted on each side of the threshold. The polynomial order is 1, and the optimal bandwidths are derived under the MSERD procedure. Coefficients are conventional local polynomial estimates; standard errors, clustered at the district-year level, are in parentheses, and p-values are robust bias-corrected following Calonico et al. (2014). The mean gives the average outcome value for male candidates at the threshold. All regressions include controls for far-left, left, right, far-right, and other.

Table D24: Differences between how female and male candidates adjust their campaigns between the 1st and 2nd round in terms of agentic vs communal language (controlling for enrolled voters)

Panel A: Agentic language

	(1) Overall	(2) Female-stereotyped	(3) Male-stereotyped	(4) Other
Woman	0.001	-0.000	0.004	0.001
	(0.016)	(0.028)	(0.035)	(0.016)
Robust p-value	0.909	0.976	0.775	0.859
Observations	798	798	798	798
Eff. number of obs	341	267	260	293
Polyn. order	1	1	1	1
Bandwidth	3.223	2.526	2.339	2.789
Mean, left of threshold	0.038	0.043	-0.031	0.046

Panel B: Communal language

	(1) Overall	(2) Female-stereotyped	(3) Male-stereotyped	(4) Other
Woman	0.049	0.005	0.033	0.026
	(0.014)	(0.015)	(0.015)	(0.011)
Robust p-value	0.001	0.700	0.037	0.033
Observations	798	798	798	798
Eff. number of obs	281	373	227	364
Polyn. order	1	1	1	1
Bandwidth	2.634	3.658	1.991	3.511
Mean, left of threshold	-0.018	-0.016	0.012	0.002

Notes: The outcome is the change between the first- and second-round platforms in the share of segments written in an agentic register (Panel A) or in a communal register (Panel B); their construction is explained in Section 3.3.2. Column (1) uses all segments of the platform; columns (2) to (4) restrict attention to the segments classified in each topic group, so that the measure is the register used within that content and is not mechanically affected by changes in topic salience. Each column reports the results from a separate local polynomial regression. The variable of interest is being a woman rather than a man. All regressions control for the number of enrolled voters. Separate polynomials are fitted on each side of the threshold. The polynomial order is 1, and the optimal bandwidths are derived under the MSERD procedure. Standard errors, clustered at the district-year level, are in parentheses, and p-values are robust bias-corrected following Calonico et al. (2014). The mean gives the average outcome value for male candidates at the threshold.

Table D25: Differences between how female and male candidates adjust their campaigns between the 1st and 2nd round in terms of agentic vs communal language (covariate-adjusted form)

Panel A: Agentic language

	(1) Overall	(2) Female-stereotyped	(3) Male-stereotyped	(4) Other
Woman	-0.002	-0.009	0.000	0.011
	(0.018)	(0.024)	(0.028)	(0.017)
Robust p-value	0.888	0.837	0.777	0.399
Observations	963	963	963	963
Eff. number of obs	264	263	299	231
Polyn. order	1	1	1	1
Bandwidth	2.108	2.097	2.418	1.849
Mean, left of threshold	-0.023	0.072	-0.045	0.084

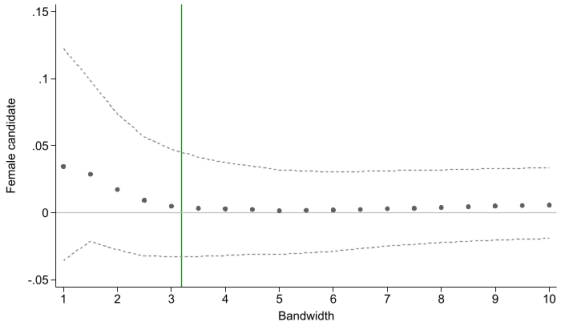
Panel B: Communal language

	Overall	Female-stereotyped	Male-stereotyped	Other
Woman	0.037	0.010	0.030	0.016
	(0.012)	(0.013)	(0.014)	(0.010)
Robust p-value	0.003	0.365	0.023	0.148
Observations	963	963	963	963
Eff. number of obs	318	352	225	421
Polyn. order	1	1	1	1
Bandwidth	2.627	2.929	1.800	3.516
Mean, left of threshold	-0.002	-0.002	-0.010	0.020

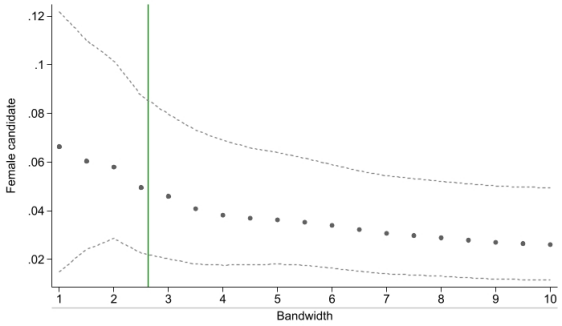
Notes: The outcome is the change between the first- and second-round platforms in the share of segments written in an agentic register (Panel A) or in a communal register (Panel B); their construction is explained in Section 3.3.2. Column (1) uses all segments of the platform; columns (2) to (4) restrict attention to the segments classified in each topic group, so that the measure is the register used within that content and is not mechanically affected by changes in topic salience. Each column reports the results from a separate local polynomial regression. The variable of interest is being a woman rather than a man. Separate polynomials are fitted on each side of the threshold. The polynomial order is 1, and the optimal bandwidths are derived under the MSERD procedure. Standard errors, clustered at the district-year level, are in parentheses, and p-values are robust bias-corrected following Calonico et al. (2014). The mean gives the average outcome value for male candidates at the threshold. All regressions include the covariates listed in Tables C12 and C14.

Figure D.8: Gender differences in campaigning style between 1st and 2nd round - Robustness to bandwidth choice

(a) Agentic



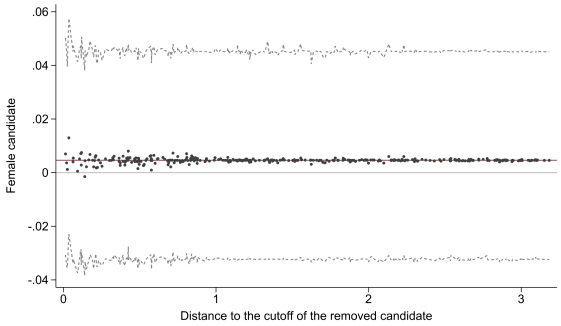
(b) Communal



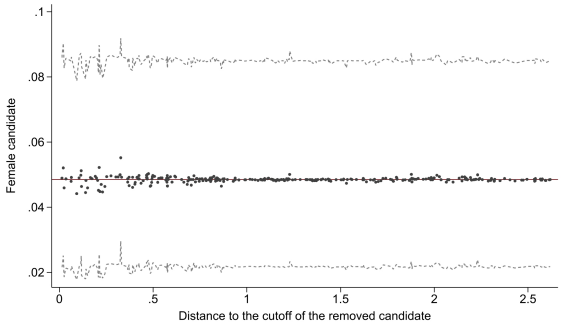
Notes. These figures show the sensitivity of the point estimate to bandwidth choice. Dots represent the estimated treatment effect using different bandwidths (horizontal axis). Dotted lines represent the 95-percent robust confidence interval. The estimates are reported for values of the bandwidth from 1 to 10 percentage points, in steps of 0.5 percentage points. The vertical green line gives the value of the MSERD optimal bandwidth used in the main estimation. The outcome is the change in the respective campaigning style between the first and the second-round. The independent variable is an indicator equal to 1 if the female candidate reached the second-round, 0 if it is a male.

Figure D.9: Gender differences in communication style adjustment between 1st and 2nd round - Leave one candidate out

(a) Agentic



(b) Communal

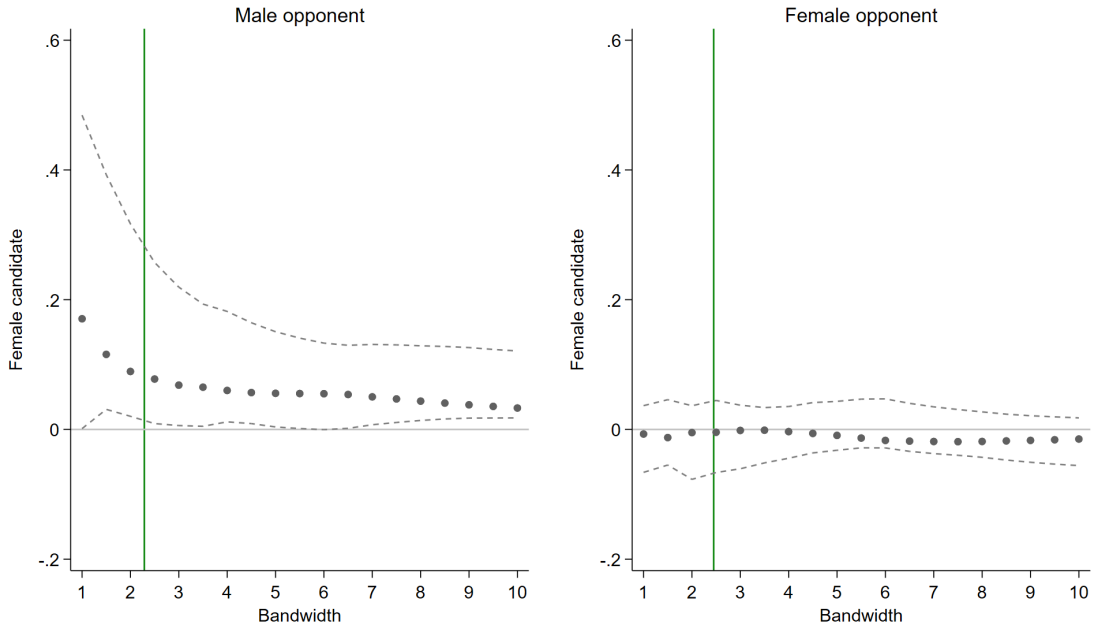


Notes. These figures show the sensitivity of the point estimate when removing one candidate at time. The very first dot on each graph provides the baseline estimate. Then, each dot provides the point estimate associated with removing a given candidate. Candidates are ordered based on the absolute value of their running variable, so that the second dot provides the point estimate associated with removing the candidate the closest to the cutoff. Dotted lines represent the 95-percent robust confidence interval. The outcome is the change in the respective topic coverage between the first and the second round. The independent variable is an indicator equal to 1 if the female candidate reached the second-round, 0 if it is a male.

E Mechanisms

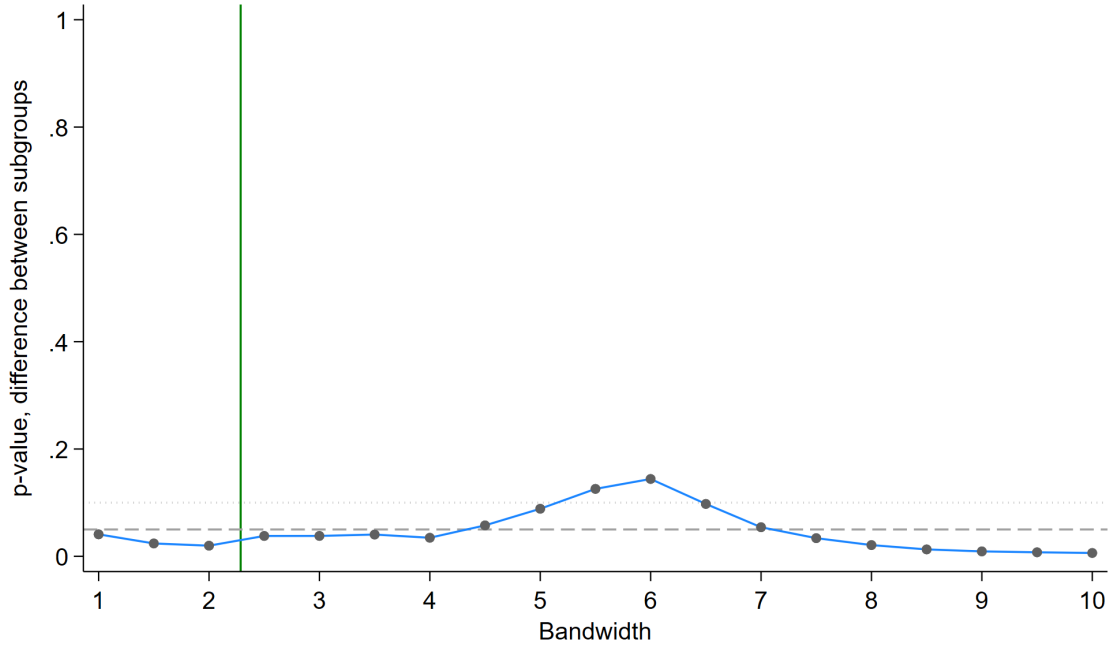
E.1 Do candidates strategically adapt to the gender of their opponent?

Figure E.10: Differences in male-stereotyped topic adjustment between female and male candidates depending on the gender of the 2nd round opponent - Robustness to bandwidth choice



Notes. These figures show the sensitivity of the point estimate to bandwidth choice. Dots represent the estimated treatment effect using different bandwidths (horizontal axis). Dotted lines represent the 95-percent robust confidence interval. The estimates are reported for values of the bandwidth from 1 to 10 percentage points, in steps of 0.5 percentage points. The vertical green line gives the value of the MSERD optimal bandwidth used in the main estimation. The outcome is the change in the female-stereotyped topic coverage between the first and the second round. The independent variable is an indicator equal to 1 if the female candidate reached the second round, 0 if it is a male.

Figure E.11: P-value: differences in male-stereotyped topic adjustment between female and male candidates depending on the gender of the 2nd round opponent - Robustness to bandwidth choice



Notes. These figures show the sensitivity of the point estimate to bandwidth choice. Dots represent the estimated treatment effect using different bandwidths (horizontal axis). Dotted vertical lines represent the 0.05 and 0.1 p-value. The estimates are reported for values of the bandwidth from 1 to 10 percentage points, in steps of 0.5 percentage points. The vertical green line gives the p-value obtained in the main estimation.

E.2 Gender differences and electoral competitiveness

Table E26: Differences in topics adjustment between female and male 2nd round political candidates - Heterogeneity by victory margin in the 1st round between the candidate and the opponent by topic

	Health		Education		Justice		Immigration	
	Below	Above	Below	Above	Below	Above	Below	Above
Panel A: Heterogeneity with discretized victory margin								
Woman	-0.046	-0.020	0.015	-0.009	0.021	0.005	0.096	0.018
	(0.022)	(0.030)	(0.033)	(0.029)	(0.038)	(0.030)	(0.102)	(0.045)
P-value (above)=(below)	0.116		0.493		¿	0.354	0.069	
Observations	399	399	399	399	399	399	399	399
Eff. number of obs	101	163	127	155	161	128	126	156
Robust p-value	0.002	0.758	0.653	0.599	0.215	0.941	0.049	0.961
Polyn. order	1	1	1	1	1	1	1	1
Bandwidth	1.772	3.138	2.297	3.008	2.996	2.288	2.260	3.085
Mean, left of threshold	0.005	0.008	-0.028	-0.014	-0.011	-0.017	-0.090	-0.014
Panel B: Heterogeneity with linear victory margin								
Woman at 0 margin	-0.005		0.002		-0.011		-0.038	
	(0.033)		(0.029)		(0.036)		(0.063)	
Robust p-value	0.807		0.489		0.214		0.222	
Woman # victory margin	0.003		0.000		-0.004		-0.012	
	(0.003)		(0.003)		(0.005)		(0.008)	
Robust p-value	0.111		0.273		0.099		0.013	
Polyn. order	1		1		1		1	
Bandwidth	2.428		3.673		3.033		2.418	
Eff. number of obs	526		752		640		526	
Observations	798		798		798		798	

Victory margin is the difference between the share of votes the candidate received in the first round and the opponent's share in the second-round. In Panel A, Below refers to candidates whose victory margin is below the median, while Above refers to candidates whose victory margin is above the median. In Panel B, victory margin is a continuous variable. Standard errors in parentheses are clustered at the district-year level. Each column reports the results from a separate local polynomial regression. The variable of interest is being a woman rather than a man. Separate polynomials are fitted on each side of the threshold. The polynomial order is 1, and the optimal bandwidths are derived under the MSERD procedure. The heterogeneity analysis is performed following Calonico et al. (2025). The dependent variables take values between 0 and 1, and their computation is explained in Section 3.3.1. The mean gives the average outcome value for male candidates at the threshold.

E.3 Discussion of alternative mechanisms

Table E27: Differences in campaign funding between female and male 2nd round political candidates

	(1) Total expenditures	(2) Total revenues	(3) Personal contribution	(4) Party contribution	(5) Private donation
Woman	1,774	2,379	506	-1,124	3,055
	(20,646)	(20,093)	(7,611)	(7,871)	(12,144)
Robust p-value	0.913	0.849	0.934	0.746	0.690
Observations	779	779	778	778	778
Eff. number of obs	301	326	303	312	404
Polyn. order	1	1	1	1	1
Bandwidth	2.906	3.162	2.943	3.030	4.106
Mean, left of threshold	50,056	50,312	28,503	7,558	13,184

Notes: Standard errors in parentheses are clustered at the district-year level. Each column reports the results from a separate local polynomial regression. The variable of interest is being a woman rather than a man. Separate polynomials are fitted on each side of the threshold. The polynomial order is 1, and the optimal bandwidths are derived under the MSERD procedure. Coefficients are conventional local polynomial estimates; standard errors, confidence intervals, and p-values are robust bias-corrected following Calonico et al. (2014). The dependent variables are, in euros: total amount raised by the candidate during the campaign, total expenditures, own funds, contributions from the party, and private donations. The sample is restricted to the candidates used in the main analysis. The mean gives the average outcome value for male candidates at the threshold.

Table E28: Differences in campaigns between female and male opponents that reached the runoff

	Topics			Campaign style	
	Female-stereotyped	Male-stereotyped	Other	Agentic	Communal
		First-round			
Woman	-0.004	0.031	-0.017	0.003	0.003
	(0.030)	(0.059)	(0.036)	(0.026)	(0.030)
Observations	745	745	745	745	745
Eff. number of obs	248	399	286	261	270
Robust p-value	0.890	0.609	0.565	0.850	0.872
Polyn. order	1	1	1	1	1
Bandwidth	2.507	4.437	2.923	2.735	2.872
Mean, left of threshold	0.117	0.165	0.879	0.085	0.068
		Adjustment between first and second-round			
Woman	0.014	-0.029	0.012	0.030	-0.004
	(0.024)	(0.031)	(0.029)	(0.030)	(0.021)
Observations	728	728	728	728	728
Eff. number of obs	272	383	289	241	310
Robust p-value	0.550	0.264	0.498	0.222	0.868
Polyn. order	1	1	1	1	1
Bandwidth	2.882	4.292	3.022	2.503	3.265
Mean, left of threshold	-0.032	-0.040	0.022	0.013	0.007

Standard errors in parentheses are clustered at the district-year level. Each column reports the results from a separate local polynomial regression. The variable of interest is being a woman rather than a man. Separate polynomials are fitted on each side of the threshold. The polynomial order is 1, and the optimal bandwidths are derived under the MSERD procedure. Coefficients are conventional local polynomial estimates; standard errors, confidence intervals, and p-values are robust bias-corrected following Calonico et al. (2014). The dependent variables take values between 0 and 1, and their computation is explained in Section 3.3. The mean gives the average outcome value for male candidates at the threshold. There are 17 platforms missing in the second-round for the opponents.

Table E29: Differences in topics adjustment between female and male 2nd round political candidates

	Topics			Campaign style	
	Female-stereotyped	Male-stereotyped	Other	Agentic	Communal
Woman	-0.035	0.022	-0.016	0.037	0.052
	(0.028)	(0.032)	(0.047)	(0.038)	(0.029)
Robust p-value	0.341	0.545	0.796	0.181	0.013
Woman × Elim. women	-0.003	0.009	-0.003	-0.010	-0.004
	(0.006)	(0.010)	(0.011)	(0.006)	(0.004)
Robust p-value	0.410	0.123	0.310	0.400	0.295
Observations	798	798	798	798	798
Eff. number of obs	334	266	232	335	280
Polyn. order	1	1	1	1	1
Bandwidth	3.166	2.474	2.039	3.192	2.628

'Elim. women' stands for the share of votes obtained by the eliminated women in the first round demeaned by election-year. Standard errors in parentheses are clustered at the district-year level. Each column reports the results from a separate local polynomial regression. The variable of interest is being a woman rather than a man. Separate polynomials are fitted on each side of the threshold. The polynomial order is 1, and the optimal bandwidths are derived under the MSERD procedure. The heterogeneity analysis is performed following Calonico et al. (2025). The dependent variables take values between 0 and 1, and their computation is explained in Section 3.3. The mean gives the average outcome value for male candidates at the threshold.